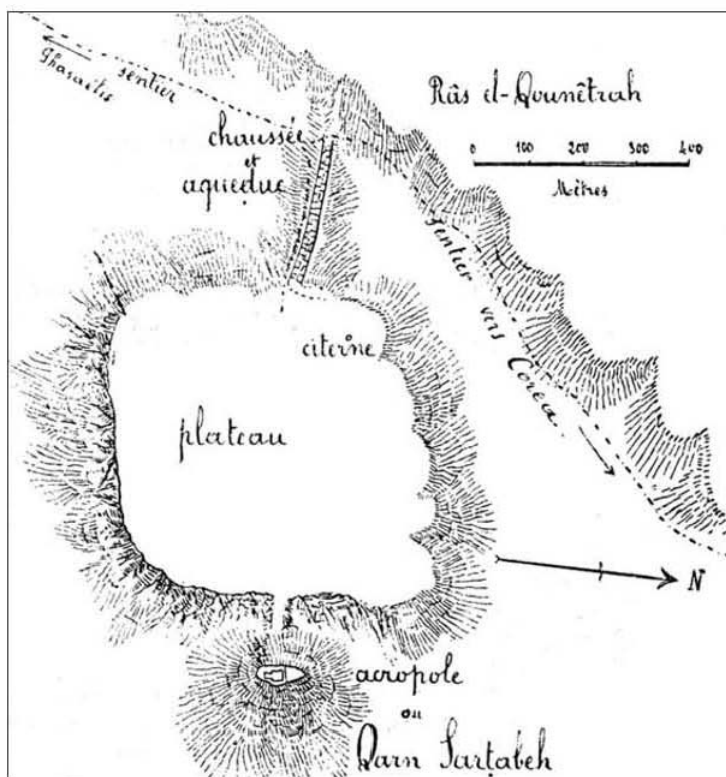
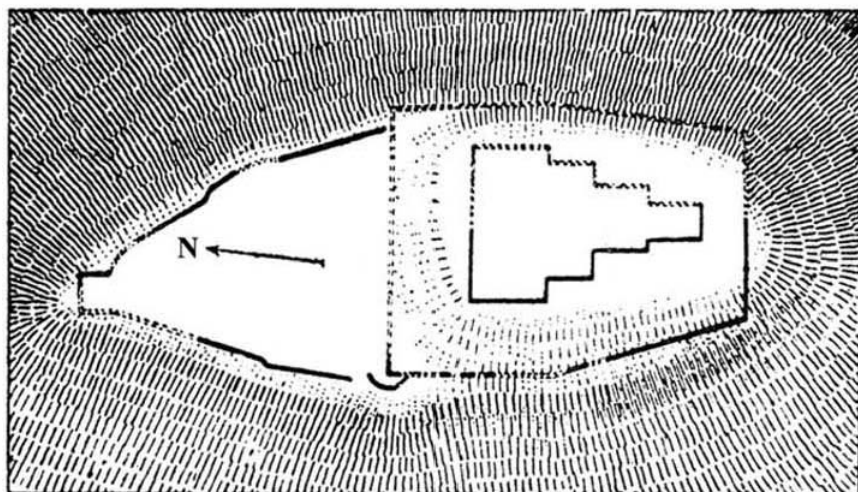




335. Plan of the siphon, lower Sartaba and the Sartaba Fortress as measured by Abel in 1910 (Abel 1913: ill. 6).



336. A plan of the summit of the Sartaba Fortress as published by Abel (1913: ill. 7).

1936:18).

3. "As per the present fragment of wall, one notes a mingling of differing types of dressing, and also notes that some blocks have been dressed on the face, while in the case of others the process is incomplete. Such a blending of smooth and rough faces might belong to the period suggested before [Herodian, A. Z.], but it may be questioned whether the present fragment of wall comes from that time. Entirely apart from possible dislocations by lightening [sic], or by seismic disturbances, the joints are altogether too poor, and the reconstruction too slipshod to suit Herodian work. The present walls appear rather to be the careless and makeshift erection of some later day, possibly by Arabs. Much better work below ground would doubtless be brought to light by excavation." (Moulton 1936:18).

D. Excavations: between 1981 and 1984 Tsafir and Magen (1984;1993) conducted three seasons of excavations in a limited area in the east side of the site, below the summit. These excavations have not been published. Three building phases were noted during the excavations: 1. From the Hellenistic period (Hasmonean); 2. A Herodian peristyle hall; 3. A 1st century CE settlement.

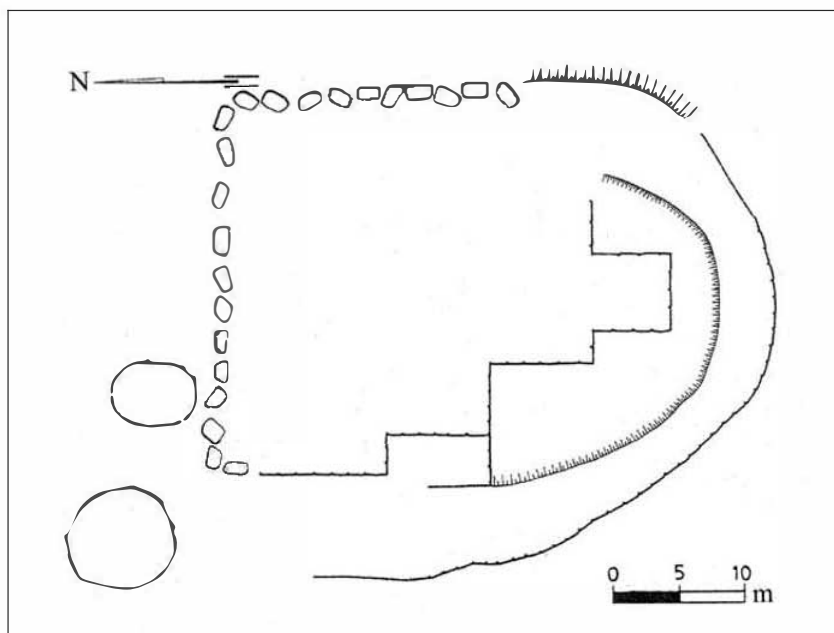
D1. Hasmonean building: beneath the Herodian peristyle were found Doric capitals and other parts of a splendid portico or facade. The excavators propose that the structure was destroyed by Gabinius in 57 BCE;

D2. Herodian peristyle: this is a square structure, the length of whose sides is 29.2 m, built on a step in the base rock plus fill. Aligned with the corners are four colonnades. The cross-section of the corner columns is heart-shaped. Coloured plaster has been preserved on some of the columns. At the centre of the hall were found remains of a mosaic floor. A cistern and a small pool were also exposed. The western wall is especially thick. There are similarities in style and methods of construction between the Herodian buildings at Masada and those of the peristyle in the Sartaba. Many sherds of the Eastern Sigillata type were found on the floor of the hall.

D3. The settlement in the 1st century CE: this settlement is attributed to the Roman garrison, and includes a baking stove and layers of ash over the preceding structures.

The small find includes coins, pottery, and storage jars, on some of which are inscriptions in Hebrew, Aramaic and Greek. Noteworthy are the names Pinhas Bar... (Pinhas son of...) and Levi Bar... (Levi son of...). The building was buried in a violent earthquake, which according to the excavators occurred 200–300 years after the abandonment.

E. New aspects: our Survey team visited the Sartaba on many occasions from



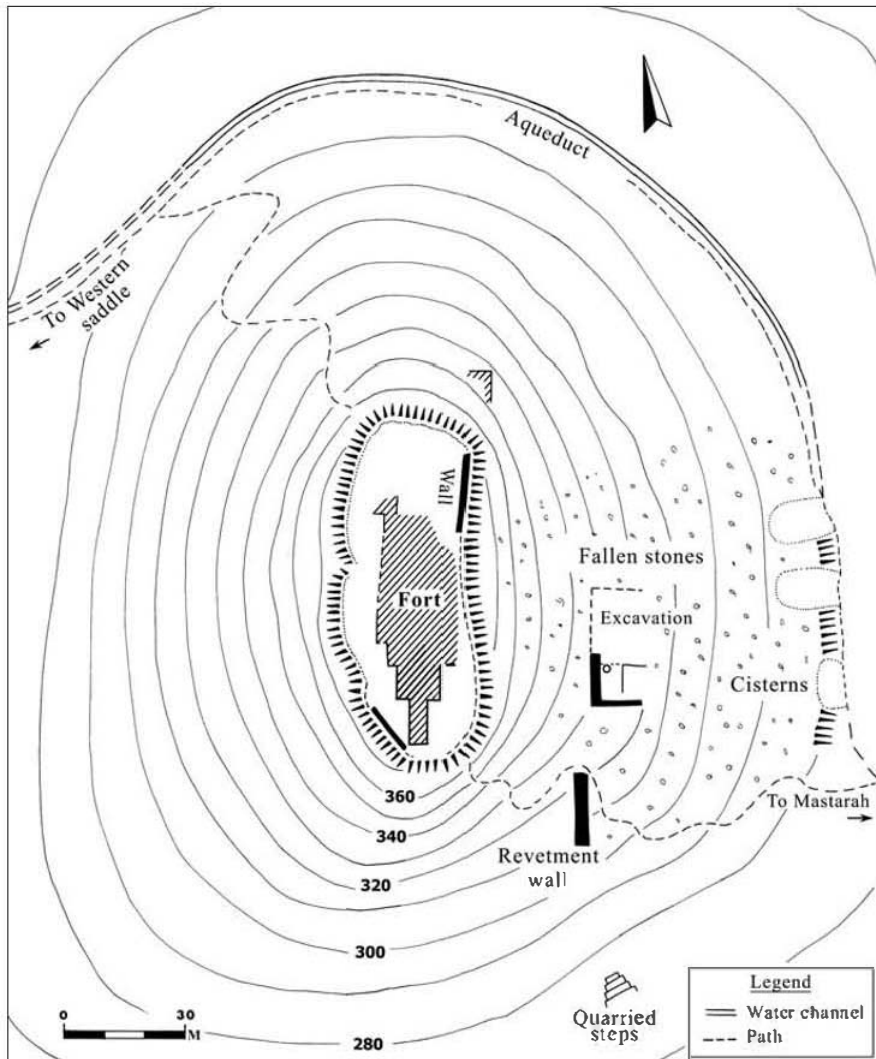
337. The plan of the Sartaba Fortress summit as published by the Emergency Survey (Bar-Adon 1972: 103).



338. The excavation area of the peristyle of Sartaba Fortress, showing the stone collapse from the structure on the summit. View to the west, 1998 (M. Einav).

1993 until recently. Two new plans have been drawn: that of the summit, and the entire mountain cone (in this entry). The bottom site on the western shoulder, the siege works and the water system have been explored (with a specific entry for each). An additional collection of sherds has also been made in the site, verifying the finds of this expedition and the previous ones. In addition to the above, IA pottery was also found.

Scrutinizing the upper citadel raises several issues. According to Abel's plan, which appears to be the most reliable and complete, the summit is divided into two: the northern half appears to be a levelled surface, while the citadel



339. Plan of the citadel and water system in the Sartaba Fortress, 1996.

stands on the southern half, which is 30x20 m and is a stepped structure. Such a form of a citadel is unknown in other sources in the Hellenistic era, and the roots of such an architectural design are unclear. We assume that a unique structure stood on the summit. The stone cutting practices do not conform, as already noted by Abel and Albright, to the acceptable standards of Herodian construction. Large-scale excavations are needed to address these issues.

Another issue is that of the excavations on both sides of the citadel. In various areas of the summit there are excavations whose nature is not clear. The first and deepest one is in the south-western part of the fortress. In this place the fill was removed to a depth of three to four courses, thus making a trench. This represents the original foundation trench in which the bottom courses of the citadel were laid. Therefore it could be concluded that these courses were built inside the trench which was then filled. This filling remained *in situ* in the more northern part, raising the questions of who removed it, and when. However, Abel and Albright considered it to be a moat, but this is not plausible. Other excavations were found to the east and alongside the first one, and also on the northern summit. Apparently these excavations already existed in 1870, during Guérin's visit.

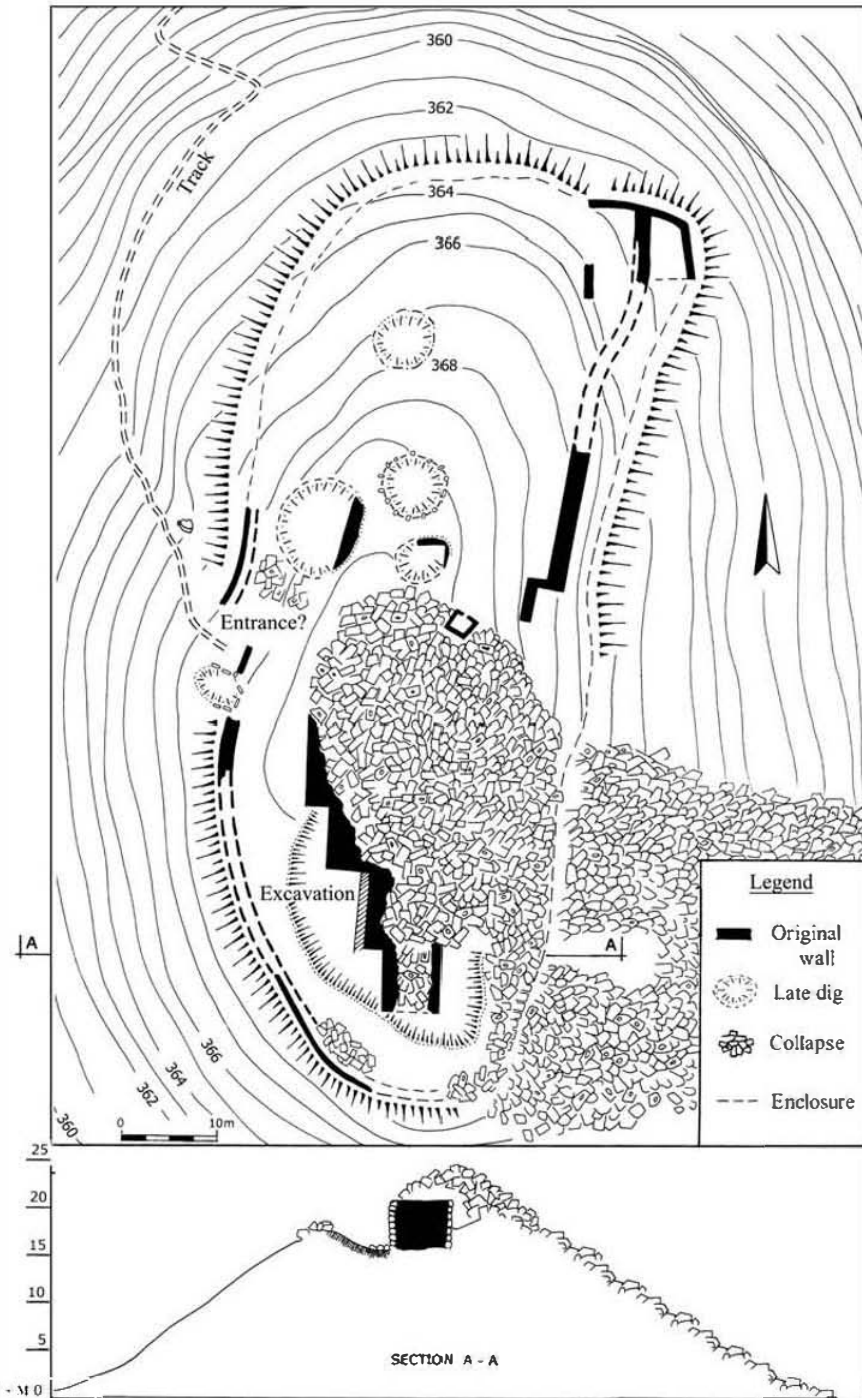
The newest issue concerning the site is the suggestion by Zertal that the Sartaba was actually a Herodian beacon. The function of the fortress (as is mentioned in the Mishnah), was kindling the beacons and spreading the news of the exact time of the appearance of the new moon from Jerusalem to the Jewish diaspora. For a complete presentation of this new idea see Zertal 2015.

Examining the location of the fortress in the area, our team has concluded that the citadel was but one element of a system, and the fortifications occupied almost the whole of the Sartaba plateau.

Pottery: Iron I-II – 2%; Hellenistic – 30%; Early Roman – 45%; Late Roman – 10%; Byzantine – 8%; Middle Ages – 5%.

Flint: 15 items, see Appendix A.

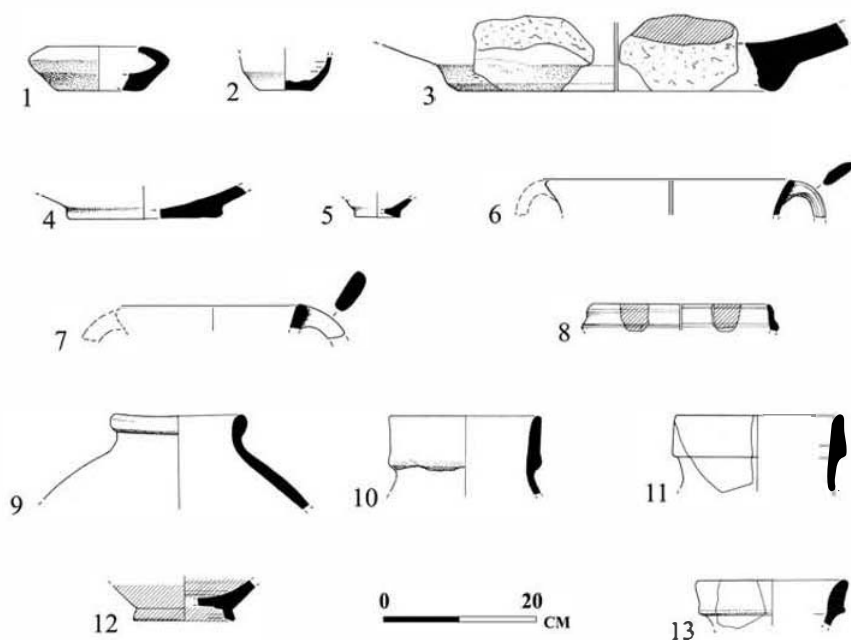
Additional Bibliography: Glueck 1951: site 253b; Porath 1968: site 168; Ilan 1973: 298-308; Tsafir 1975; Marcus 1992: 115-118; Guri-Rimon 1996: 17-18; Tsafir and Magen 1993 (with additional Bibliography); Meshel 2003; *NEAEHL* 5: 2110 (for additional Bibliography).



340. Detailed plan and cross-section of the summit of the Sartaba Fortress, 2002.
Note the excavation in the southern part and the robbing pits.



341. Aerial view to the east of the Sartaba plateau and the cone of the Sartaba Fortress, 1997 (M. Einav).



342. Pottery from the Sartaba Fortress: 1. Bowl, pk, Hel; 2. Base of juglet, buff, Hel; 3. Base of bowl, rd slip inside, Hel; 4. Base of bowl, rd, ER; 5. Base of juglet, buff, Hel; 6-7. CPs, brn, Rom.; 8. Bowl, buff with rd slip, ER; 9. Jar, buff, Hel; 10-11, 13. Jars, lt gr, Hel; 12. Base of juglet, rd slip, Hel.

Site 173 (1): 19-16/47/1

KHARBET KOUFA

Israel grid: 1941/1673

UTM grid: 7327/5543

Elevation: 244 m a.s.l., 200 m a.s.a.

Name: local

Site type: medium-sized

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein Jeruzaliyeh (172),
1.3 km distantRoad: Mastarah-Sartaba (C44),
500 m distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 150 sherds

A medium-sized site on the northern ridge of the Sartaba near E.P. 244, and 2.7 km south-west of Masua. From the site are extensive views, mainly eastwards, to the Jordan Valley and the Jordanian mountains.

The remains of thin walls were found at several locations at the site, but no clear remains of structures were noted. The main features found were a 30 m-long wall at the eastern part of the site that closes off the approach to the site from the east, and a robbed tumulus in the western part.

A large sherd scatter is visible.

The site was previously visited by several scholars. Guérin (1969: 244) ascended the Sartaba fortress on April 25, 1870, describing a site at the bottom of the mountain, which he called Kharbet Koufa. He located the site on the northern lower summit, and reported that all the area was covered with sherds and medium-sized stones originating from ruined buildings. He suggests that these are ancient quarries from which were cut the building stones which were used for the building of this village and the Sartaba.

Meshel described the siege system around the Sartaba (Meshel 1989), and suggested that this place was a military camp that he denoted as "Camp IX", and that the circumvallation reached the site from the north and the south-west on the very steep slopes of the ridge. His suggestion is mainly based on logical and topographical reasons, and we did not find circumvallation remains near the site or any finds to further support his idea.

Kharbet Koufa is a Hellenistic and ER site whose function and relationship with the Sartaba fort are still not clear.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 30%; Early Roman – 70%.

Additional surveys: Meshel 1989.

Additional Bibliography: Einav 2014.

Site 174: 18-16/65/1

E.P. 416

Israel grid: 1864/1659	Soil quality: 8
UTM grid: 7250/5527	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 380 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: 2
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Majdal (185), 1.2 km distant
Site type: courtyards	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 700 m distant
Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)	Visit: Dec. 1998; 69 sherds
Topography: valley margins	
Rock type: Judea Group	
Soil type: terra rossa	

Three courtyards at the south-western edge of Wadi el-Miniyah, on a moderate slope descending from E.P. 416 hill. The location of the site is about 300 m from the Maale Ephraim–Gittit road, and about 2 km north-west of Maale Ephraim.

All the yards are encircled by a well-constructed wall about 1 m thick, built of two rows of large field stones.

Yard 1 is irregular in shape, measuring about 40×40 m. In its higher part a sort of terrace is visible, and in the lower part there is rounding of the corners by small stones.

Yard 2 is about 130 m south-east of yard 1. In the western part there is also an additional construction, forming an inner room or enclosure. The stones of the south-eastern wall have been removed, and only some fragments of it have survived. Outside, next to this wall, is an active cistern with a stone trough.

Yard 3 is similar in measurements to yard 2, but its form is irregular. In the south-eastern side an entrance 1 m wide built of two jambs has been preserved. A small enclosure measuring about 15×10 m is attached outside on the eastern side.

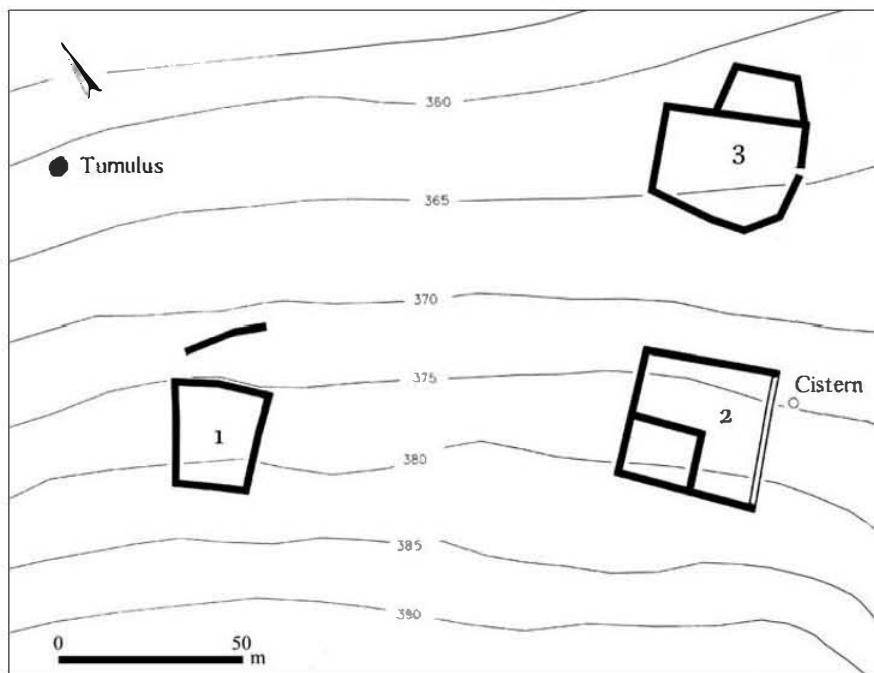
About 70 m north of yard 1, close to the border of the cultivated valley, is a stone tumulus, and next to it are various other constructions. Along the rim of the valley a variety of walls and parts of a pathway built between two walls have survived.

Porath (1968: site 182) mentions a pen, a cave and a cistern at Israel grid 1861/1656, with sherds dated to the Ir II, Byz and MA.

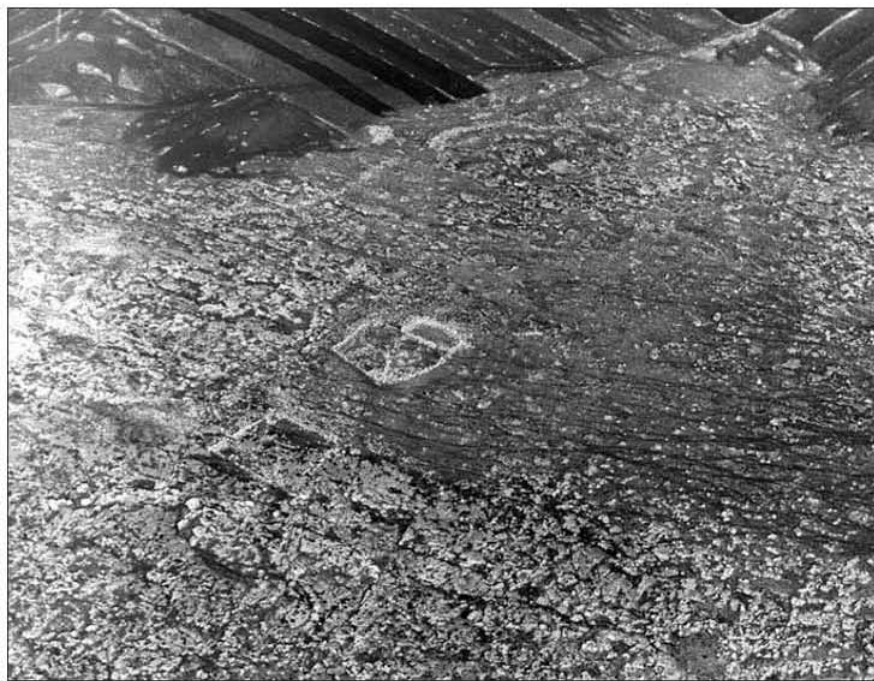
Pottery: Iron II – 15%; Late Roman – 40%; Byzantine – 30%; Middle Ages – 15%.

Flint: 11 items, see Appendix A.

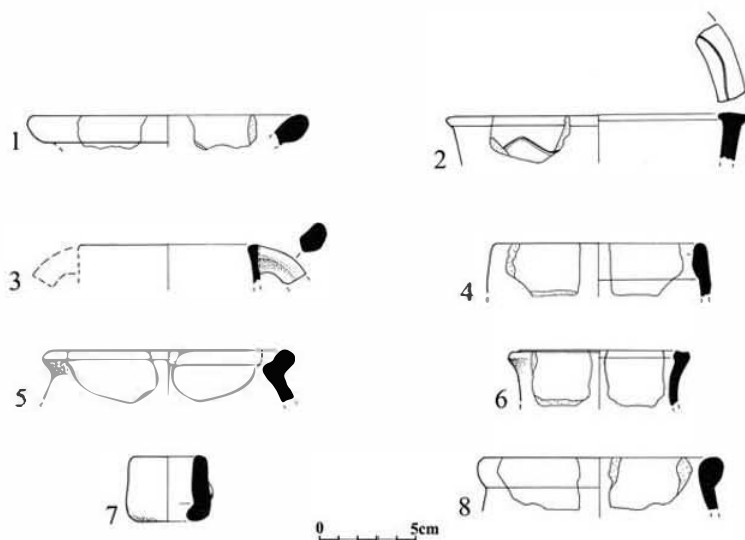
Previous surveys: none.



343. Plan of E.P. 416, 1998.



344. Aerial view to the north-east of the courtyards at E.P. 416, 1999 (M. Einav).



345. Pottery from E.P. 416: 1. Jar, rd, Rom; 2. Bowl, lt brn, LR/Byz; 3. CP/jar, pk, LR/Byz; 4. Jar, buff, MA; 5. Bowl, brn, Ir II; 6. Jar, buff, LR; 7. Small bowl, gr, MA?; 8. Jar, brn, Ir II.



Site 174 (1): 18-16/65/2

WADI ES-SUKHUN (1)

Israel grid: 1868/1651

UTM grid: 7254/5519

Elevation: 300 m a.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure and courtyard

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: valley fringe

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
1.8 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
400 m distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 20 sherds

A structure and adjacent courtyard on a shoulder on the edge of a valley above the southern bank of Wadi es-Sukhun, 1.5 km north-west of Maale Ephraim, and 800 m south-east of E.P. 416.

A structure, possibly a field tower built of very large stones, stood here. The structure has collapsed and it is difficult to trace its original measurements,

but it seems that it was originally about 5×5 m. Adjacent to the structure is an oval courtyard, 13×19 m in size, built of medium-sized and large stones.

50 m to the south-east is another structure, 4×8 m in size, built of very large stones. The opening is at the north-east. In the area below all these structures is a small field with ancient terraces.

This site, and other nearby sites, such as the adjacent Wadi es-Sukhun (2) site, are part of Rom–Byz agricultural operations in this area.

Pottery: Roman-Byzantine – 90%; Middle Ages – 10%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 174 (2): 18-16/65/3

WADI ES-SUKHUN (2)

Israel grid: 1866/1653

UTM grid: 7253/5521

Elevation: 310 m a.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure, enclosure and cave

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: valley fringe

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Majdal (185), 1.8 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41), 400 m distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 15 sherds

A structure at the edge of a valley on a shoulder above the southern bank of Wadi es-Sukhun, 1.7 km north-west of Maale Ephraim, and 400 m south-east of E.P. 416.

A structure, possibly a field tower built of very large stones, stood here. Its dimensions are 4×8 m, and the walls are almost 1 m thick and 2 courses high. Below the structure are wall remains, possibly parts of a dismantled courtyard.

About 150 m to the north, up the wadi bed and near the stony slope, are the remains of another poorly preserved courtyard and a collapsed cave above it (at coordinates 1866/1655).

This site, and other nearby sites, such as the adjacent Wadi es-Sukhun (1) site, are part of Rom–Byz agricultural operations in this area.

Pottery: Roman-Byzantine – 100%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 175: 18-16/85/1

‘EIN ES-SUKHUN

Israel grid: 1887/1651	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7273/5519	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 50 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest spring	Water source: ‘Ein es-Sukhun (175), at the site
Site type: prehistoric	Road: Fasa’el-Ṭana (C40), next to the site
Area: 50 dunams (5 ha)	Visit: Feb. 1997
Topography: narrow slope of wadi	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A prehistoric site next to a small gravity spring in the upper part of the wadi, on a slope north to Wadi Sukhun. The site is about 600 m north of the settlement of Maale Ephraim, and close by to the east is the unpaved road from Maale Ephraim to the Alon road.

The spring is 60–70 m above the stream bed. At the site, the northern slope is much more moderate than the southern one. In the upper part of the northern slope is a 500-m line of cliffs, and the spring is at its foot. Below these cliffs is a rockfall of large boulders and stones covering the slope. The inhabitants took advantage of this for building terraces and stabilizing the slope.

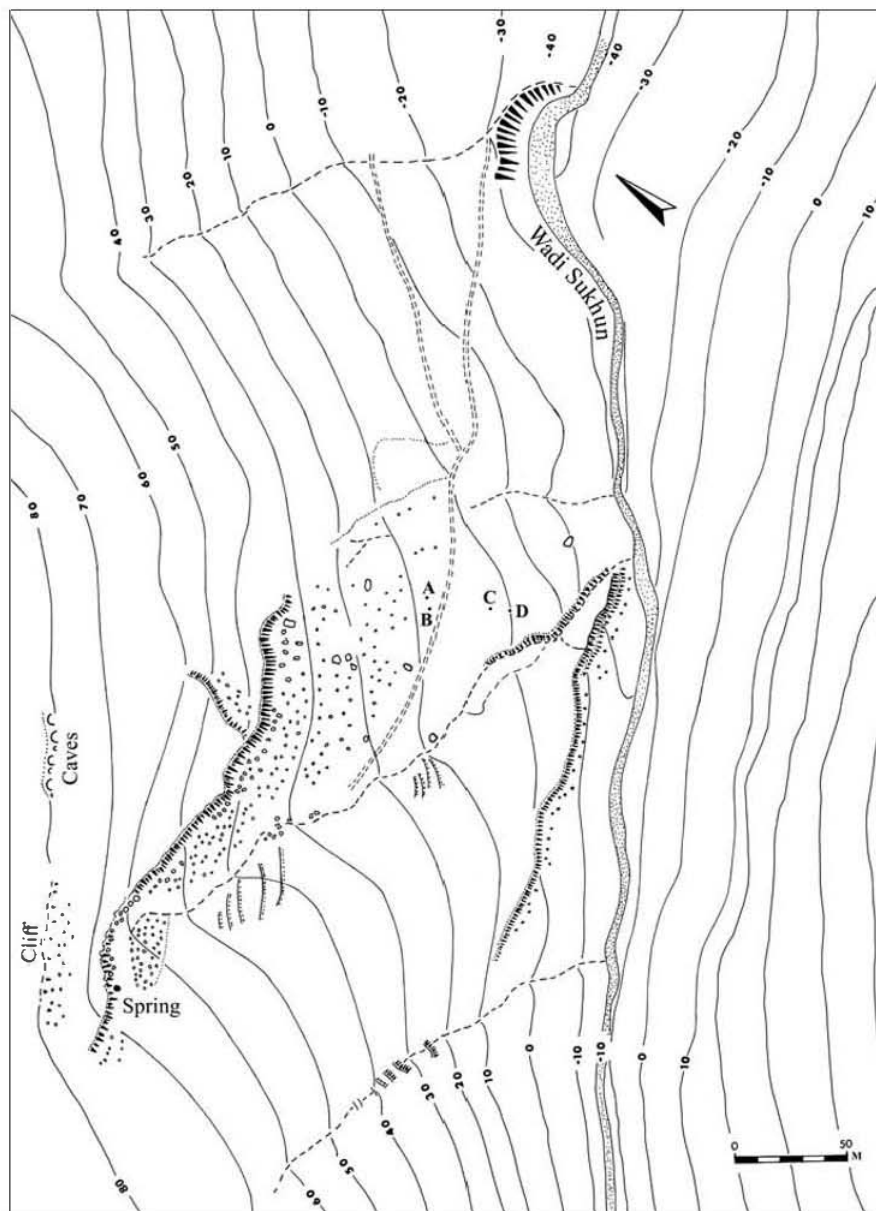
The water discharge of the spring is small and a plastic pipe carries the water to the nearby Bedouin encampment. The spring is reached from the stream bed by a path built in the rocky slope that has been considerably terraced since ancient times. There is an abundance of flint items by the terraces and among the fallen boulders on the slope. Rock-cut cup-marks were found in the locations marked A–D in the plan. At the head of the cliff are niches and caves.

Flint: 271 items, Pre-Pottery Neolithic A-B periods, see Appendix A.

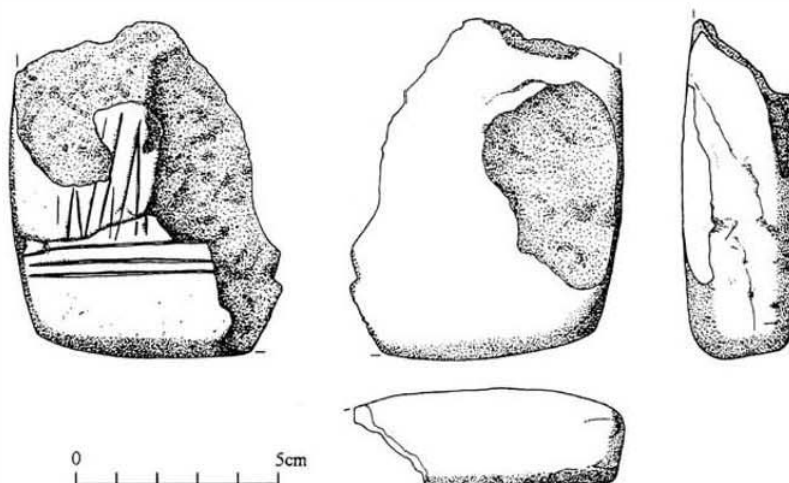
Stone: 12 items, Pre-Pottery Neolithic A-B periods (see Eitam 2005: 716–718).

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Nadel et al. 2000.



346. Plan of 'Ein es-Sukhun and surroundings, 1997. The cup-marks are marked A–D.



347. An engraved stone from 'Ein es-Sukhun.



348. The spring at 'Ein es-Sukhun, 1997. The Bedouin draw water from it through a plastic pipe for their flocks (M. Einav).

Site 175 (1): 18-16/85/2

E. P. 138 (1)

Israel grid: 1881/1657

UTM grid: 7267/5525

Elevation: 180 m a.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure and prehistoric

Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)

Topography: flat hilltop

Rock type: hard limestone

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
700 m distantRoad: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
1.7 km distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 90 sherds

A site on the very gentle slopes of a flat hilltop between Wadis es-Sukhun and Abu el-Layel, 1.2 km north of Maale Ephraim, and 700 m west of E.P. 138.

The site is composed of two adjacent courtyards: the eastern one is rectangular, 12×15 m, and the western one is almost square, 12×13 m. The masonry of the yards is identical, with small- and medium-sized stones, and only one course surviving. The average width of the walls is 40 cm, one stone wide. In a number of locations along the walls a widening was noticed with the addition of a second line of stones to the width of the wall. Two modern structures were also found, one inside the western courtyard, and the other 5 m to the north of this yard.

A large flint scatter is spread around the yards, attesting to an earlier prehistoric site. This is only a small part of the very large prehistoric site occupying the entire summit and slopes of the flat hilltop (see Site 175 [2]).

Pottery: Roman-Byzantine – 90%; Middle Ages – 2%; Ottoman – 3%; Unidentified – 5%.

Flint: 65 items, Epipalaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 175 (2): 18-16/85/3

E. P. 138 (2)

Israel grid: 1883/1656	Soil quality: 5
UTM grid: 7269/5524	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 180 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175), 500 m distant
Site type: agricultural and prehistoric	Road: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41), 1.7 km distant
Area: 20 dunams (2 ha)	Visit: Dec. 2015; 180 sherds
Topography: flat hilltop	
Rock type: hard limestone	
Soil type: terra rossa	

A very large agricultural and prehistoric site on a flat hilltop and its moderate slopes between Wadis es-Sukhun and Abu el-Layel, 1.1 km north of Maale Ephraim, and 600 m west of E.P. 138.

On the centre and southern part of the flat and stony hilltop were found the unusual number of 12 large threshing floors. Most of them are oval or rounded and between 12 and 20 m across. The masonry is similar – small- or medium-sized stones, usually one course high, surrounding a bare stone surface. The surface is usually 50 cm deeper than the surrounding wall. This height difference was achieved by constructing the surrounding walls on natural higher surfaces, or by erecting these walls on a raised earth foundation.

Between the threshing floors were found six U-shaped structures built of small stones, surviving to the height of 1 m. We have encountered many such structures during the survey, and date them mostly to Ottoman or Modern times, but their location here close to the threshing floors might indicate that they were used for storage in the Middle Ages and/or the Ottoman period. Another possibility is that they were constructed later from the abundant stones available from the walls of the threshing floors.

This was a centre of agricultural activities in the region. It seems that it was already established in the IA II, but the main periods of occupation were in the Rom–Byz periods, and it continued to function in the Middle Ages and Ottoman period. This is a fine example of the vast Rom–Byz agricultural operations in eastern Samaria.

The prehistoric site was larger than the agricultural site, and occupied the entire hill and its slopes. Hundreds of flint items are scattered all over it. It is important to note the proximity of the natural bedrock to the modern surface, implying that we are probably not dealing here with deep ancient prehistoric deposits, but rather moderate scale operations on the rocky surfaces.

The prehistoric site might be connected to the nearby sites at 'Ein es-Sukhun (Site 175) Elevation Point 138 (1) (Site 175 [1]), and Elevation Point 138 (5) (Site 175 [5]).

Pottery: Iron II – 3%; Roman-Byzantine – 85%; Middle Ages – 5%; Ottoman – 3%; Unidentified – 4%.

Flint: 168 items, Neolithic, see Appendix A.

Stone: 15 basalt cobbles used in threshing tools.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 175 (3); 18-16/85/4

E. P. 138 (3)

Israel grid: 1886/1656

UTM grid: 7272/5524

Elevation: 140 m a.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure and enclosures

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: ridge

Rock type: hard limestone

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
400 m distant

Road: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
2 km distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 70 sherds

A farm on a ridge south and above the deep Wadi Abu el-Layel, 1.2 km north-north-east of Maale Ephraim, and close to E.P. 138.

In the site is a rectangular structure, 4×8 m, built of medium- and large-sized stones. Abutting it from the south and the west are two similar oval courtyards or threshing floors built of medium-sized stones and measuring 10×20 m. East of the structure are three oval threshing floors similar in size to the yards adjacent to the structure.

Near the site is a terraced inner valley. There are more terraces on the slope in the direction of the wadi.

It seems that the site was already established in the IA II, but the main periods of occupation were in the Rom-Byz periods. This is another example of the vast Rom-Byz agricultural operations in the region.

Pottery: Iron II – 7%; Roman-Byzantine – 90%; Middle Ages – 3%.

Additional surveys: none.

Site 175 (4): 18-16/85/5

E. P. 138 (4)

Israel grid: 1884/1657

UTM grid: 7271/5525

Elevation: 140 m a.s.l., 70 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure and enclosure

Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)

Topography: slope

Rock type: hard limestone

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
600 m distantRoad: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
2.3 km distant

Visit: Dec. 2015; 20 sherds

A structure and an adjacent courtyard on a slope south and above Wadi Abu el-Layel, 1.4 km north of Maale Ephraim.

A rectangular structure measuring 5×9 m, built of very large stones. Adjacent from the south-east is an oval courtyard 9×18 m.

Only a few sherds were found dating the place to the Rom-Byz periods. This is probably another example of the vast Rom-Byz agricultural operations in the region.

Pottery: Roman-Byzantine – 85%; Unidentified – 15%.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 175 (5): 18-16/85/6

E. P. 138 (5)

Israel grid: 1885/1655

UTM grid: 7271/5523

Elevation: 140 m a.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: prehistoric

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: moderate slope

Rock type: hard limestone

Soil type: terra rossa

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: uncultivated field

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
400 m distantRoad: Fasa'el-Neapolis (C41),
1.6 km distant

Visit: Dec. 2015

A large flint scatter in an uncultivated field and a moderate slope descending to Wadi es-Sukhun, 500 m south-west of E.P. 138, and 1 km north of Maale Ephraim.

Many flint items are scattered over a large area. The remains of a few undated rounded walls are also visible on the surface of the slope. This site might be connected to the nearby prehistoric sites at 'Ein es-Sukhun (Site 175) and Elevation Point 138 (2) (Site 175 [2]).

Flint: 134 items, see Appendix A.

Additional surveys: none.



Site 176: 18-16/95/1

ES-SAHLAT

Israel grid: 1896/1655

UTM grid: 7282/5523

Elevation: 50 m b.s.l., 30 m a.s.a.

Name: ancient, but not on map

Site type: courtyard and enclosures

Area: 10 dunams (1 ha)

Topography: shoulder

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: brown forest

Soil quality: 6

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
900 m distant

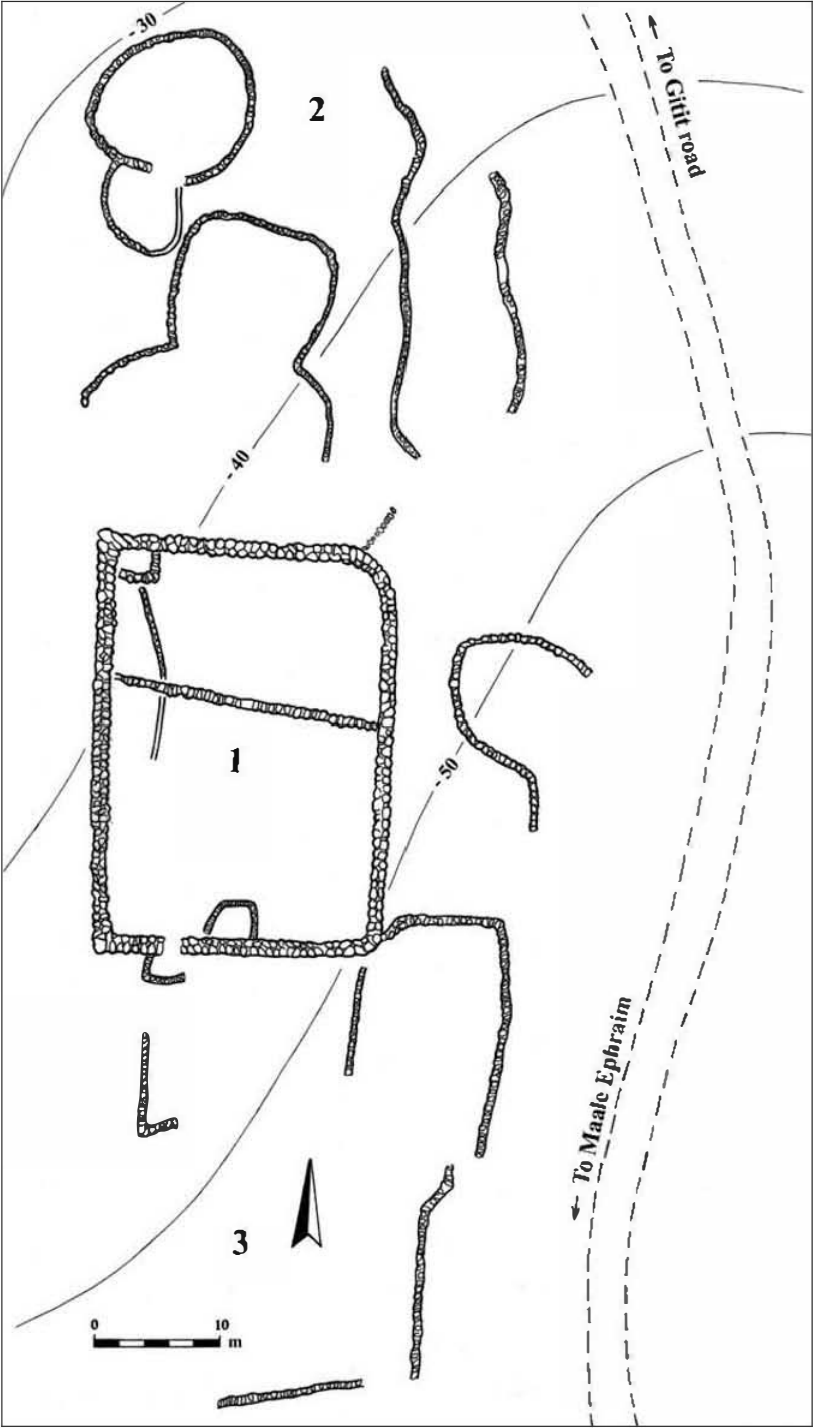
Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
next to the site

Visit: Feb. 1997; 75 sherds

A complex site on the north bank of Wadi es-Sukhun, north of the spot where the wadi is crossed by the unpaved Maale-Ephraim–Gittit road. This is also a junction of other unpaved roads and wadis: one road goes north, and another ascends north-east to EP 105 and the Sartaba. The site is about 2 km north-east of Maale-Ephraim.

The site is in an internal basin next to the stream, surrounded by lofty ridges. It has three parts, apparently chronologically distinct:

1. A rectangular courtyard measuring 35×25 m, built of two rows of large stones. The yard is well preserved, in places up to a height of four courses. The dry construction is of good quality. In the south-western side a constructed 1 m-wide opening has survived; outside is a semicircular wall protecting the entrance. The yard is divided by a wall into two parts – two-thirds and one-third of the area. Along the western wall are remnants of



349. Plan of es-Sahlat, 1997.



350. Aerial view to the south of es-Sahlat, 2013 (A. Solomon).

rooms, apparently preceding the yard's construction. In addition, there are 'cells' of later construction, adjacent to the yard wall on the inside. The courtyard was apparently built and used in the Rom-Byz period.

2. Remains of circular enclosures, 30-40 m north of the courtyard, built of large stones in a single row. One, 13 m in diameter, survived complete. Attached to it to the south is another smaller stone circle, joined by a passage. The remains of another enclosure were found east of the courtyard between it and the unpaved road. Of the rest of the enclosures only sections and irregular walls remain. The construction method is common to them all. It appears that the enclosures to the north preceded the courtyard and belonged to the earlier site (IA). They went out of use at the establishment of the courtyard, or even earlier.
3. To the south of the courtyard are stone terraces, apparently belonging to the rectangular courtyard phase.

The site served mainly as a farm or a cluster of enclosures from IA II, built to exploit the abundance of pasture and the nearby spring. The rectangular courtyard was built in the Roman period to serve as a farm structure or livestock pen. That use lasted through the MA. Nowadays the settlement hub has moved west to the Bedouin encampment in Wadi es-Sukhun.

Pottery: Iron II – 16%; Early Roman – 8%; Late Roman – 25%; Byzantine and Early Moslem – 32%; Middle Ages – 19%.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 121



Site 177:

ROMAN ROADS – THE SARTABA RANGE

The Sartaba range is intersected by Roman roads, mainly leading to the Sartaba Fortress (see Introductions, Section 4.2 and Fig. 8 above), and also from the Jordan Valley to the Samaria region (road C40). We have decided to designate a Site number to this road system, and especially to three uniquely preserved sections of these roads that are described below.

The main routes climbing to the Fortress of Alexandrion (Sartaba) were:

- Wadi Jeruzaliyeh road (C43) from the Jordan Valley. In some places in the Wadi the ancient path is still visible. Rujm es-Si'a fort (Site 86) at the entrance guarded the road.
- Wadi Qurein road (C45) from the south-east, north-west of Yafit. From there it passed through the wadi to reach the steep climb to the fortress. It should be noted that the climb from this spot is difficult, and we are not sure that this road actually reached the fortress walls. Meshel (1970: 105) was the first to note a set of stairs in the fortress possibly leading in this direction. The documented end of this path is a uniquely built road with unparalleled masonry (see below).
- Wadi 'Amrah path (C46) began west of Yafit and continues northward (extant). This path is convenient, taking advantage of the plateau above the Wadi to the west. Stairs cut into the rock have been discovered at coordinates 1927/1660, possibly belonging to this road (see below). It should be noted that the beginning of this road (the ascent to the Sartaba from the south) could also have been through Wadi Ahmar (which is parallel to Wadi 'Amrah on the west), and not solely through the Yafit valley and Wadi 'Amrah.

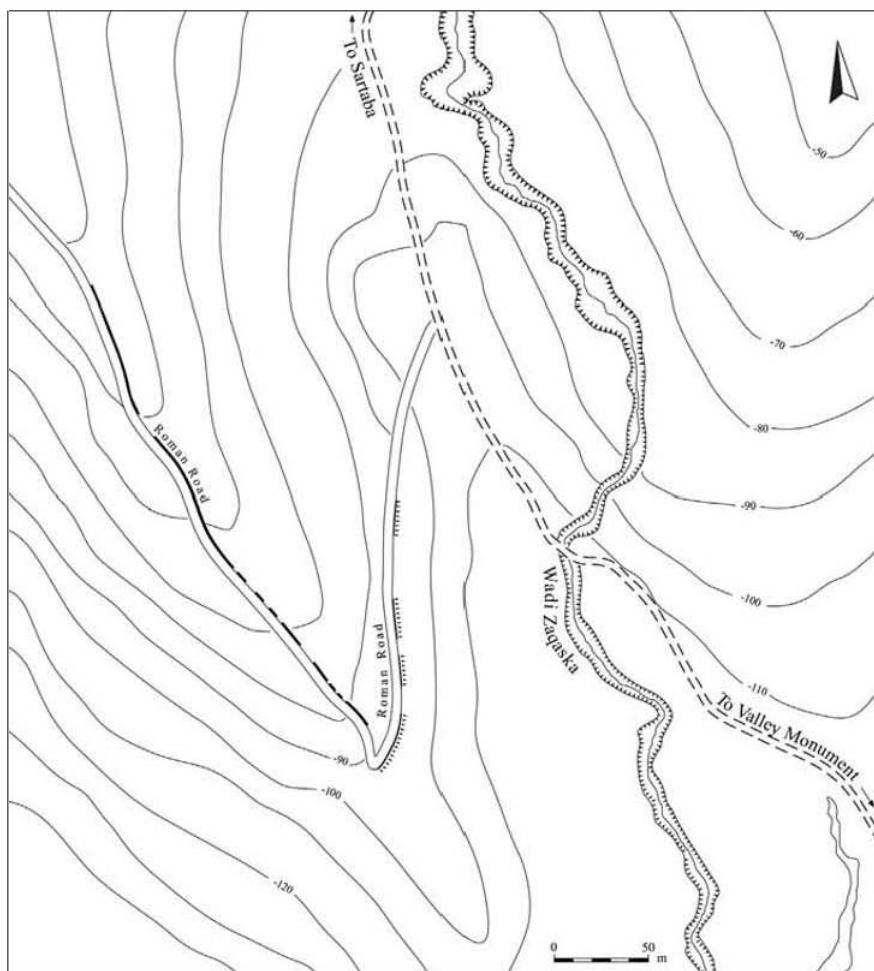
The Roman road Phasaelis–Neapolis

A section of the well-built and well preserved Roman road (C40 – Israel grid: 1910/1650; UTM grid: 7300/5525), was traced ascending over a narrow spur from south to north, reaching E.P. 105 (Site 168). The spur is located between Wadi Zaqaska, a narrow tributary of Wadi Ahmar to the east, and Wadi Sad-

Khariz in the west, which also empties into Wadi Ahmar. This section of road is included in this site because of its exceptional state of preservation. The road is part of the Phasaelis–Neapolis road (C4●) passing through the western parts of the Sartaba range.

The road has two sections: the ascent over the slope, and the spur:

- 1) The ascent: the road starts from the new unpaved road ascending to the Sartaba, and climbs fairly steeply to the south-west. This section, about 25● m long, is built on a raised foundation across the slope, supported by stone walls up to 1 m high. Due to the steepness of the slope the pavement did not survive, only the support walls.
- 2) The spur: in this section, in the flatter eastern part of the spur, a stretch of



351. Plan of Wadi Zaqaska area and the Roman road – Phasaelis–Neapolis, 2002.

the road at least 1 km long, 5–6 m wide, has survived. A row of the large kerbstones and the stone slab paving have also survived.

While surveying the region, we searched for its probable ascent to Alexandrion or its descent to 'Ein Hafireh, in both cases to no avail.

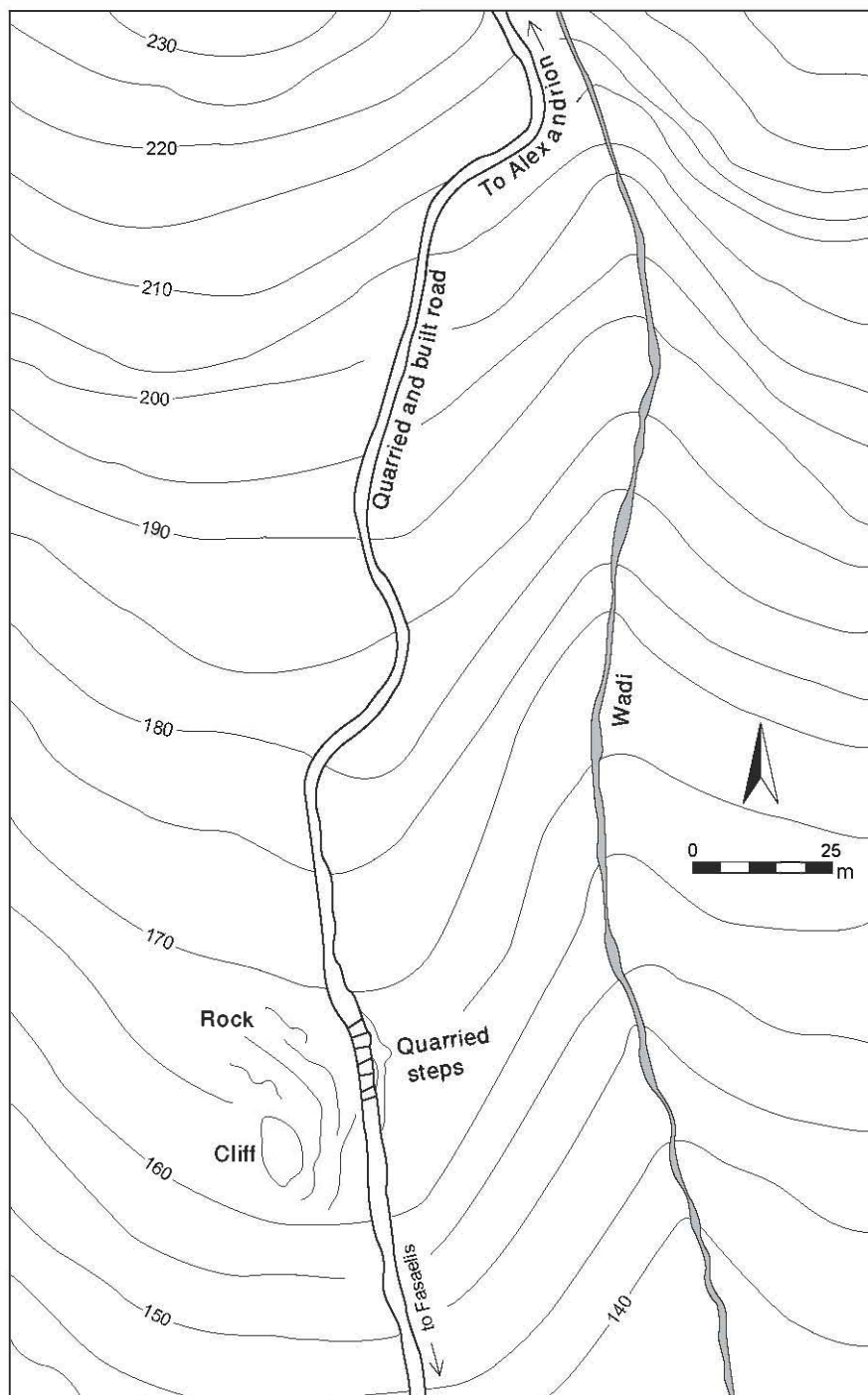
The rock-cut stairs southwest of the Sartaba fortress

Rock-cut stairs were found south-west of the Sartaba. These probably belonged to a road ascending to the fortress from the south. Candidates for such a road are either the Wadi 'Amrah path (C46-see above), or an unknown road from Phasaelis to the fortress through Wadi Ahmar (Einav 2012: 634). Einav suggests that, together with the foundation of Phasaelis and the refortification of Alexandrion, the southern approach road to the fortress was also paved. Apparently, most of the remains of this road have been washed away, except for the stairs and another section north of them. For restoration of the route Einav made use of the topography and the walking paths of the modern Bedouin, suggesting some paths ascending from the Ahmar valley in the direction of the stairs, and from them further north to the siphon.

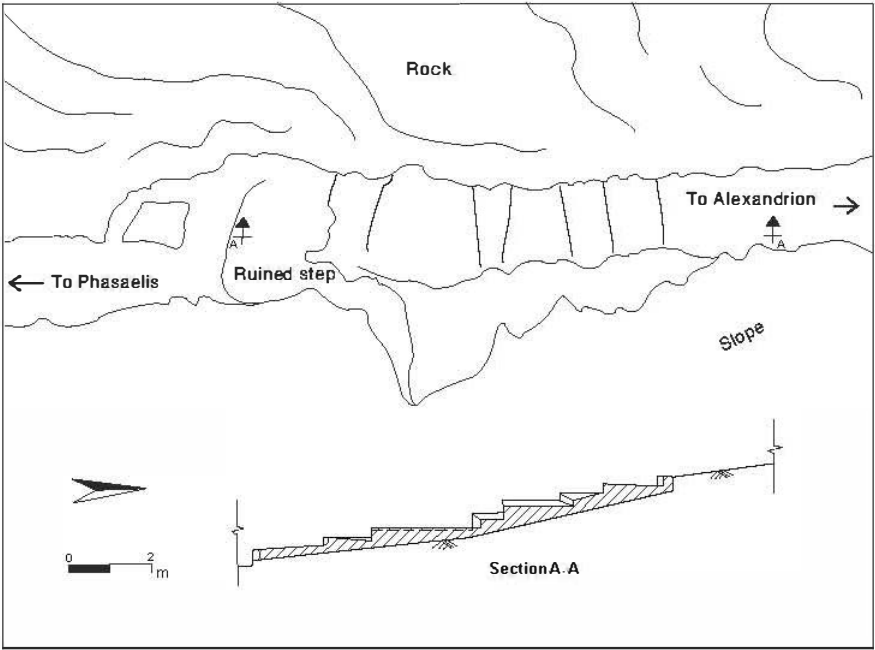
The surviving stairs in the rocky section were measured and drawn in 2012, when a coin of Alexander Jannaeus was found on the road. Seven stairs have



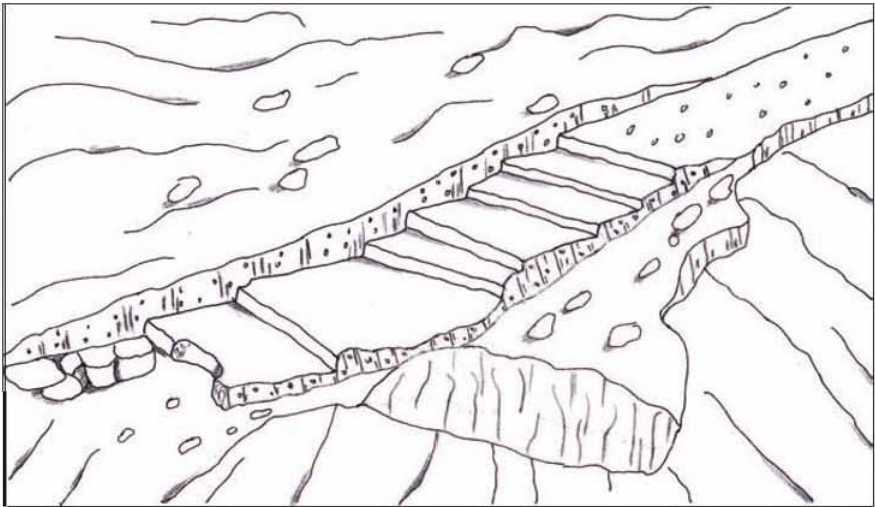
352. The southern part of the Roman road – Phasaelis–Neapolis, 1995 (M. Einav).



353. Plan of the area of the rock-cut stairs, part of the southern Roman ascent to the Sartaba, 2012.



354. Plan and section of the rock-cut stairs, part of the southern Roman ascent to the Sartaba, 2012.



355. Perspective view to the north-west of the rock-cut stairs, 2012.

survived. Their length (the path width) is 1.8–2 m each; they are about 80 cm wide and the average riser is about 20 cm. The cutting is fairly good, similar to that of other Roman stairs in this country, such as in Maale Aqrabim and the road to Jerusalem. The estimated width of the road was approximately 2 m, less than the standard for main (Imperial) Roman roads.

The rock-cut stairs in the Sartaba are probably the most ancient of their type in Israel; however, their service, and of these facilities in general, was short-lived. The fortress of Alexandrion is not mentioned after Herod, and was finally abandoned after the Great Revolt: a Roman military unit may have been settled there to prevent it from becoming a nest of rebels (Tsafrir and Magen 1993).

The stairs were part of a road ascending to the fortress. Two relevant issues arise here: their function and the date. If the road was built at the same time as Phasaelis, then it is Herodian and built in the last decades before the beginning of the Common Era. In any case, it is certain that the date is not later than Herod, and it could possibly be advanced to the reign of Alexander Jannaeus, because it is obvious that the fortress was also in use during his reign. As to the function of the roads, they are to be considered as second-class roads built according to preset technical specifications, aimed to ease travel along country roads in general.

The 'processional way' in Wadi Qurein

On the southern slope of the Sartaba, in the descent to Wadi Qurein, Meshel (1989: 299–301) discovered an ancient road he called "the Sartaba ascent". This road is different from other typical roads discovered in the survey, and resembles 'processional ways' in ritual sites (see for example in Appendix B). This is the meaning of 'processional way' as used here. The road itself did not actually reach the Sartaba fort, and its final destination was a natural podium.

The preserved road is divided into three sections:

- The first section, 200 m long and 6 m average width, was found on a long shoulder above the wadi bed. Kerbstones on both sides survive.
- The second section is short and very poorly preserved because the road was cut by the circumvallation, and descends from the shoulder and crosses a small ravine, until it reaches a steep slope below the Sartaba fort.
- In the last section the road ascends the sharp slope in a zig-zag pattern (see plan in Fig. 359). It bends sharply until it reaches a natural podium made of white *hawwar*.



356. The rock-cut stairs on the southern ascent to the Sartaba, 2012 (M. Einav).



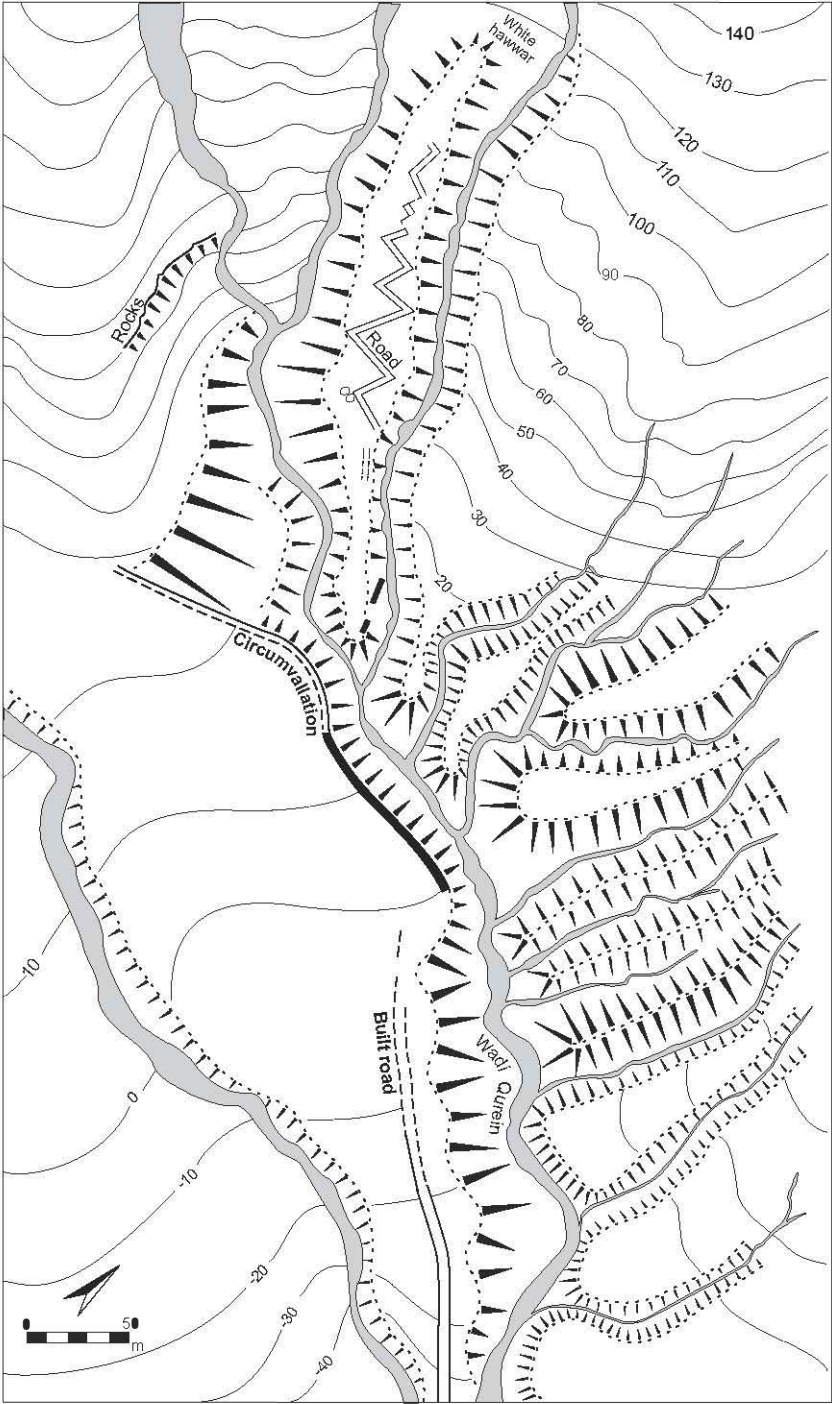
357. View of the 'processional way' in Wadi Qurein, 2015. Note the steep slope to the Sartaba fortress.



358. View to the north of the 'processional way' in Wadi Qurein, 2015.

From this point onwards the road disappears near a very steep slope made of crumbly *qirton* and clay that prevents any possibility of continuation towards the fort.

Meshel (197●) suggested that the road reached the Sartaba fort, but later (1989: 3●1) changed his mind and suggested an official use connected to the construction of the fort. We also support a ceremonial use of this road connected to the podium at its end. Maybe it was, as Meshel suggested, a road connected to construction activities, but other assumptions are also possible. Was this a road built for military parades connected to diplomatic ceremonies or burials? Only further research at the place will add to our knowledge of this mysterious 'processional way'.



359. Plan of the 'processional way' in Wadi Qurein, 2013.

Site 178: 19-16/15/3

WADI AHMAR (1)

Israel grid: 1918/1651

UTM grid: 73●5/5519

Elevation: 11● m b.s.l., 5● m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: 2.5 dunams (25●● sq. m)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Alluvium

Soil type: alluvium

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

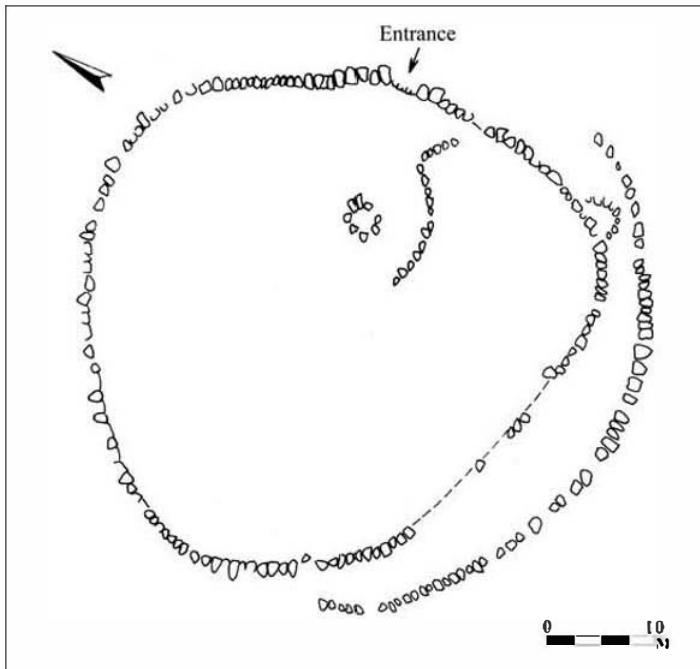
Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.1 km distantRoad: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C4●),
4●● m distant

Visit: Jan. 1996; 43 sherds

A large enclosure in the north-western part of the Wadi Ahmar valley, about 3.5 km north of Fasa'el. The site is located east of the main riverbed of Wadi Ahmar, on a wide floodplain intersected by ravines.

The enclosure is almost circular, and is about 4● m in diameter. It is built of large stones. It seems that it was built in three phases:



360. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (1), 1996.

1. In the eastern part is a section of wall, built of medium-sized stones. This is a part of an ancient rounded structure, relating to an oval structure, like a tumulus. This is possibly the ancient nucleus of the enclosure.
2. The central enclosure was probably in use during most of the time that the site existed.
3. South of the southern wall of the central enclosure is a parallel curved wall, 5–6 m outside the enclosure. Its construction is similar to that of the large enclosure, and it is probable that the builders intended to expand the latter. It is likely that the ends of the 'expansion' met the enclosure.

It appears that the enclosure had been widened twice. The method of construction, size of stones and the layout is similar to that of early IA enclosures.

Pottery: Iron I – 42%; Iron II – 5%; Late Roman – 46%; Middle Ages – 7%;
Previous surveys: none.



361. Aerial view of Wadi Alnnar (1), view to the south, 2013 (A. Solomon).

Site 179: 19-16/15/1

NAQB HARABAH (1)

Israel grid: 1915/1650	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7302/5518	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 130 m b.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 1.2 km distant
Site type: courtyard	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 600 m distant
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visits: Dec. 1995, March 2002; 24 sherds
Topography: valley margins	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A courtyard and structures in a rather narrow valley between the deep channel of Wadi Naqb Harabah and a steep slope.

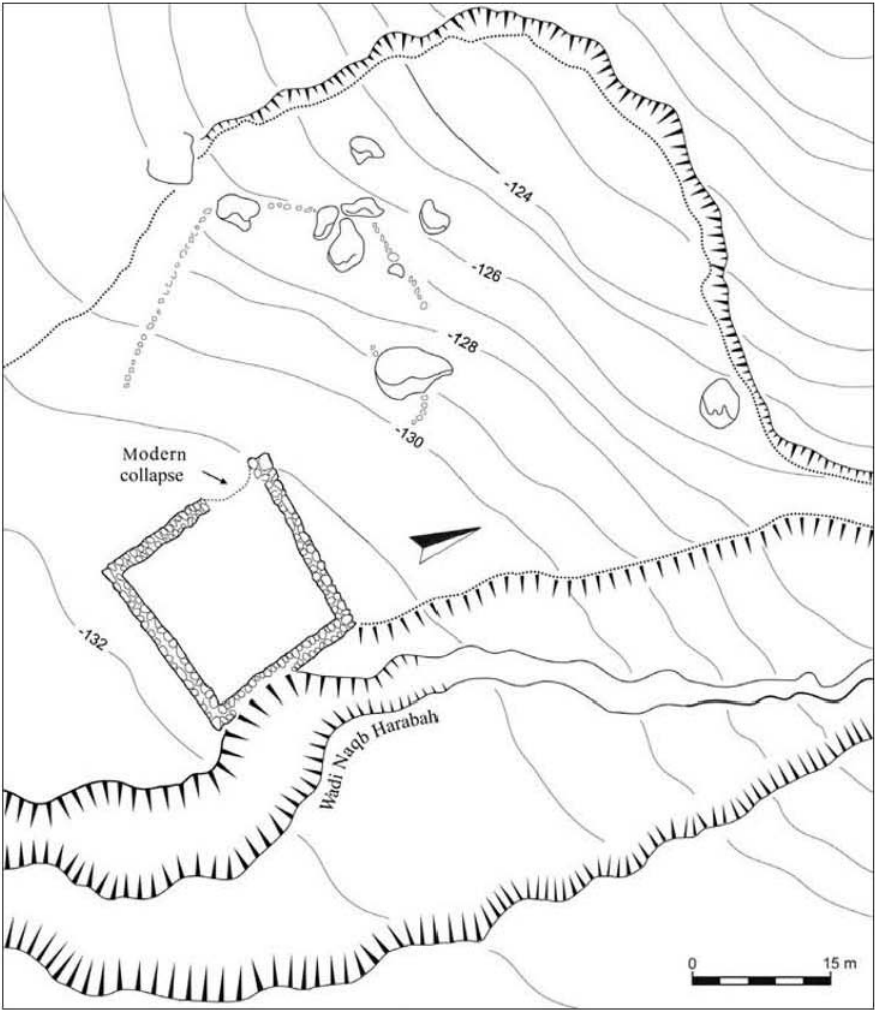
The courtyard, measuring about 22×20 m, is built on the bank of Wadi Naqb Harabah, and part of its eastern wall has been eroded by the wadi, which is about 40 m wide and about 6 m deep at this spot. The perimeter wall is 1.5 m thick, and is built of large stones. The opening seems to have been by the north-western corner, where the wall has been demolished.

North-west of the yard, in the slope, is a natural amphitheatre set into the cliffs. In this area are large boulders which rolled down the slope from the cliff. Long walls across the slope were apparently intended to protect the yard from rolling stones.

This courtyard belongs to the livestock types of yard, which are common in the region; it was in service for a long period. It now contains a Bedouin encampment.

Pottery: Late Roman – 15%; Byzantine – 60%; Middle Ages – 20%; Ottoman – 5%.

Previous surveys: none.



362. Plan of Naqb Harabah (1), 2003. It is located between the deep channel of Wadi Naqb Harabah and the natural ‘theatre’ which is down the spur.

Site 180: 19-16/14/1

NAQB HARABAH (2)

Israel grid: 1915/1649	Soil quality: 6
UTM grid: 7301/5518	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 130 m b.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
Site type: small	1 km distant
Area: 8 dunams (8000 sq. m)	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
Topography: valley margins	next to the site
Rock type: Avdat Group	Visit: Dec. 1995; 63 sherds
Soil type: stony-desert;	

A site on a surface in the margins of a valley on the western bank of Wadi Naqb Harabah, about 4 km north of Fasa'el. The unpaved road to the Sartaba passes close by. To the north rises the ridge of E.P. -26, and there is a view from the site to the expanses of the Ahmar Valley.

In the site there is a cluster of adjacent and attached structures; including broad rooms and small square rooms, both constructed of local stones. West of the cluster, towards the slope, are several enclosures which are connected or cross each other, and were built at various times. Prominent is a particularly thick wall (about 1.5 m) which curves among the enclosures.

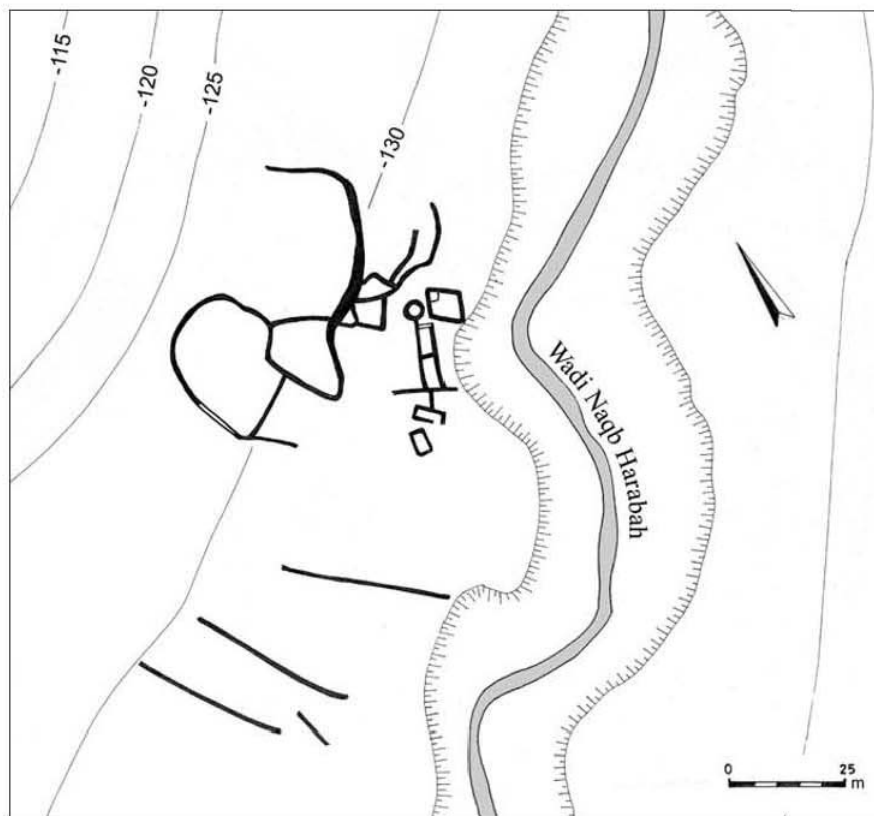
South-west of the settlement are three long straight walls; which seem to have been erosion stoppers or divisions between fields. It can be assumed that they functioned together during the existence of the settlement.

The site is one of a series of sites in the valley of Wadi Ahmar; they all share interesting well preserved architecture and sparse small finds.

Pottery: Chalcolithic/Early Bronze I –16%; Late Roman – 63%; Ottoman – 2%; Modern – 19%.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 75



363. Plan of Naqb Harabah (2), 1995.



Site 181:19-16/15/2

WADI ZAQASKA

Israel grid: 1913/1652

UTM grid: 7299/5521

Elevation: 110 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: village

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: step above wadi

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

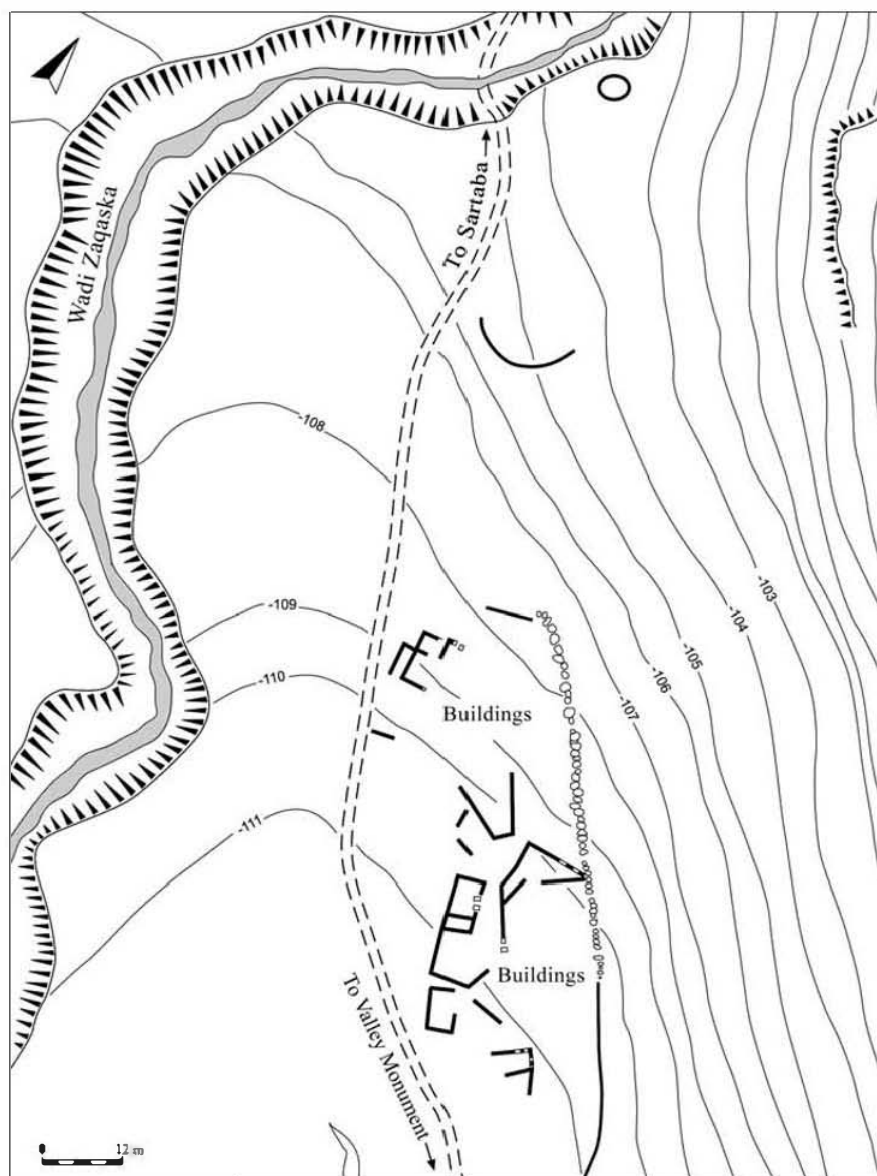
Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
700 m distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), next to the
site

Visits: Jan. 1996, March 2004;
11 sherds

A small site in the narrow valley of Wadi Zaqaska, close to the east of the unpaved road ascending to the Sartaba, 4 km north of the centre of Fasa'el.

Between the unpaved road and the steep slope which ascends south from E.P. -26, is a 'strip site', about 75 m long and 40 m wide. In this area are remains of 20-30 structures, built mostly of local flint stone. In the area are walls supporting most of the structures. Especially prominent is a long wall from



364. Plan of Wadi Zaqaska.

north to south, built of large stones, enclosing the settlement from the east. This wall was designed apparently as protection from falling stones.

Due to the intense erosion it is difficult to interpret the plans of the structures. All the walls are straight and the corners are right-angled. In some places openings are marked by standing stones.

About 50 m west of the site passes the wadi channel, and opposite it to the west on the spur the Roman road ascends to the Sartaba (Site 177).

The pottery find is very sparse, only body fragments, and the dating is unknown.

Pottery: unidentified - 100%

Previous surveys: none.



Site 182: 19-16/15/4

E.P. - 26

Israel grid: 1916/1654

UTM grid: 7303/5522

Elevation: 110 m b.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: encampment

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: step above wadi

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
600 m distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
400 m distant

Visit: Jan. 1996; 60 sherds

A small site in a closed valley in the north-western part of the Wadi Ahmar valley, 2.5 km south-west of the Sartaba.

The site is a sherd scatter on a surface in a slope over the western shoulder of Wadi Ahmar. No architecture has been found, only many encampment remains, such as organic matter and litter of a modern encampment.

Apparently, the site has been an encampment for nomads from the Byz period onwards.

Pottery: Byzantine - 18%; Early Moslem - 13%; Middle Ages - 33%; Ottoman - 16%; Modern - 20%.

Previous surveys: none.

Site 182 (1): 19-16/16/1

WADI AHMAR (10)

Israel grid: 1919/1660

UTM grid: 7306/5529

Elevation: 30 m b.s.l., 70 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)

Topography: ravine

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 1

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
600 m distantRoad: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
600 m distant

Visit: Nov. 2015; 25 sherds

An enclosure in a narrow ravine in the northern part of the Wadi Ahmar valley, 4.5 km north of Fasa'el, and 2 km south-south-west of the Sartaba.

The enclosure is located on the northern bank of Wadi Ahmar, bounded by high ridges. It is circular, 23 m in diameter, and built of small- and medium-sized stones. The width of the wall varies from 60 to 100 cm, 2 to 4 stones wide. The place is filled with eroded sediment from the ridges towering above.

The number of sherds is low. Natural flint is found in abundance in the proximity of the enclosure, and worked flint is also occasionally found, probably a sporadic use of this uncommon natural source.

The masonry of this enclosure – wide walls of small- and medium-sized stones – is not common in the Jordan Valley, where the usual enclosure construction is of large boulders.

Pottery: Iron – 20%; Late Roman-Byzantine – 60%; Middle Ages – 20%.

Flint: 48 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Site 183: 19-16/25/1

WADI AHMAR (3)

Israel grid: 1921/1655

UTM grid: 73●8/5525

Elevation: 6● m b.s.l., 1●● m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosures

Area: 4 dunam (4●●● sq. m)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

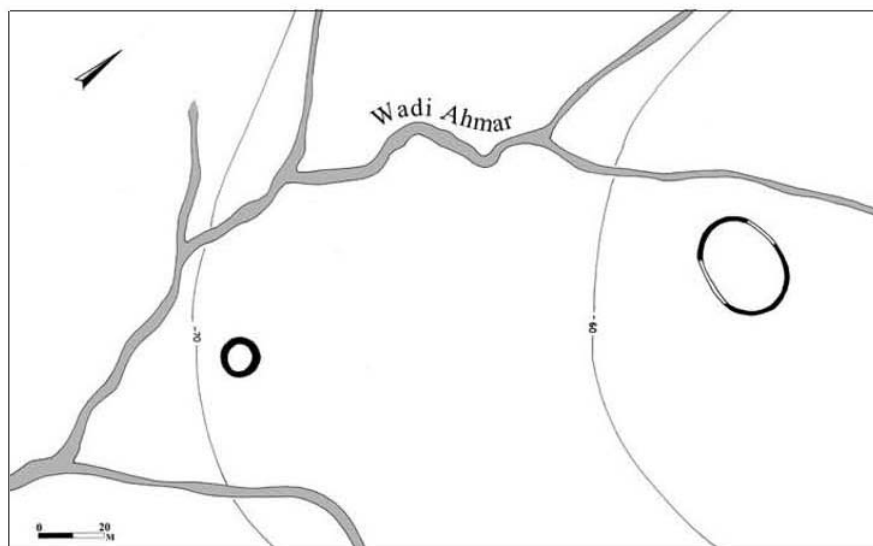
Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
7●● m distantRoad: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C4●),
1 km distant

Visit: Jan. 1996, 2●14; 4● sherds

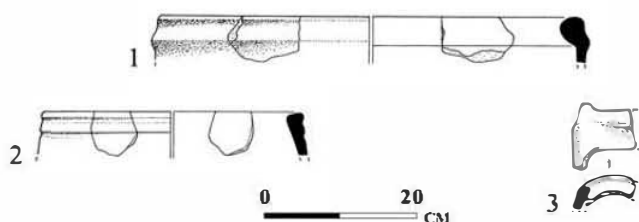
Enclosures in the northern margins of Wadi Ahmar, about 4 km north of Fasa'el.

The site is on a slightly elevated broad spur, between the shallow secondary channels of Wadi Ahmar. Two round enclosures built of large stones have been traced. The diameter of the northern one is 2● m, and it is built of one or two rows of large- and medium-sized stones. The inside of the enclosure has been cleared of stones, forming a hollow close by the stream.

About 15● m to the south is another enclosure, 7 m in diameter, built similarly to the larger one. Between and around the enclosures is a thin scatter of flint items and sherds.



365. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (3), 1996.



366. Pottery from Wadi Ahmar (3): 1. CP, dk brn, Ir II; 2. Bowl, lt brn, LR; 3. Jar handle, lt brn, Byz.

Pottery: Chalcolithic (?) – 20%; Iron II – 20%; Late Roman/Byzantine – 40%; Middle Ages – 20%.

Flint: 2 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 73.



Site 183 (1): 19-16/25/3

WADI AHMAR (11)

Israel grid: 1920/1650

UTM grid: 7306/5519

Elevation: 120 m b.s.l., 5 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: prehistoric

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: plateau

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: rendzina

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.2 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Tana (C40),
500 m distant

Visit: Nov. 2015

A flint scatter in the north-eastern margins of Wadi Ahmar, 3.5 km north of Fasa'el, and 2.6 km south-west of the Sartaba.

Natural flint is found in abundance, and worked flints are also occasionally found. This probably represents a sporadic use of this unusual natural source. A similar situation was observed 1 km to the north in Wadi Ahmar (10) site (Site 182 [1]).

Some of the flint is dated to the Pre-Pottery Neolithic A and B periods. The only site from that period in the proximity of Wadi Ahmar is 'Ein es-Sukhun (Site 175), 3.2 km west of this site.

Flint: 150 items, probably Pre-Pottery Neolithic A and B, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 184: 19-16/25/2

WADI AHMAR (4)

Israel grid: 1920/1652

UTM grid: 7306/5521

Elevation: 100 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
900 m distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
700 m distant

Visit: Feb. 1996; 35 sherds

A medium-sized site in the centre of the Wadi Ahmar valley, between two wide channels of the wadi, about 4 km north of Fasa'el.

The site includes an especially large irregular oval enclosure. It is 52 m long by 40 m wide, and its long axis is north-east-south-west. Curved walls are found near the northern and southern ends of the enclosure, terminating mid-way. These are assumed to be remains of older enclosures.

The encircling enclosure wall is built of large- and medium-sized stones, and is about 1 m thick. Inside the enclosure are remains of a smaller enclosure, about 21 m in diameter, whose eastern part is missing. The remains of a rectangular structure were also found, the walls of which turn in at a right angle.

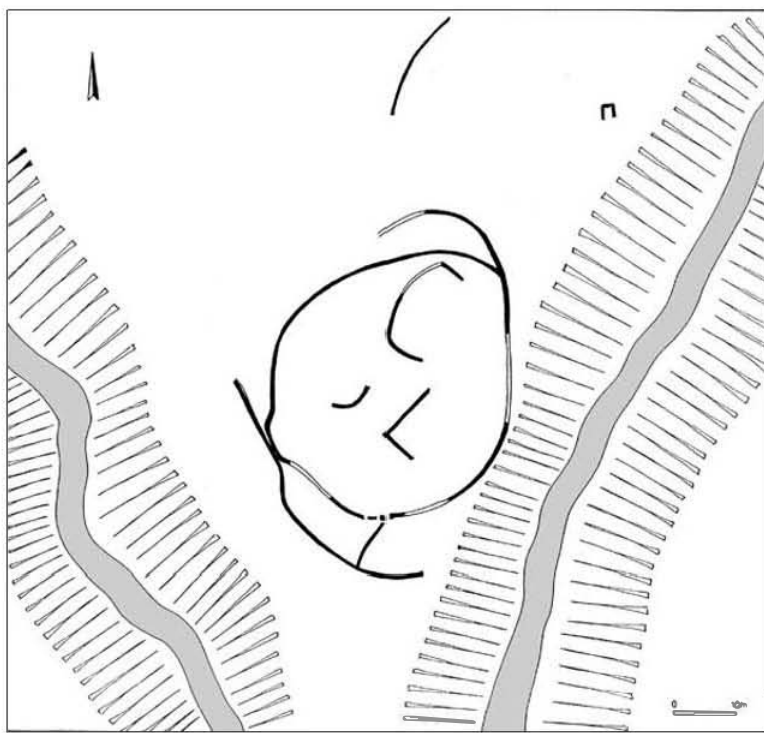
Various stages of different methods of construction are apparent. There were monoliths, and there probably were two constructed entrances in the south.

There are additional wall remains north of the large enclosure.

Pottery: Chalcolithic (?) – 60%; Late Roman – 40%.

Flint: 23 items, possibly Chalcolithic, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



367. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (4), 1996.



368. Aerial view to the north of Wadi Ahmar (4), 2013 (A. Solomon).

Site 185: 19-16/05/1

‘URQAN UMM SAFA

Israel grid: 1908/1651	Soil quality: 2
UTM grid: 7294/5519	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 50 m b.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: on map, but not as ancient site	Water source: ‘Ein el-Mana (176), 1.2 km distant
Site type: caves	Road: Fasa’el-Ṭana (C40), 200 m distant
Area: 3 dunams (3000 sq. m)	Visits: Dec. 1995, 1997; 26 sherds
Topography: cliffs and steep slope	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

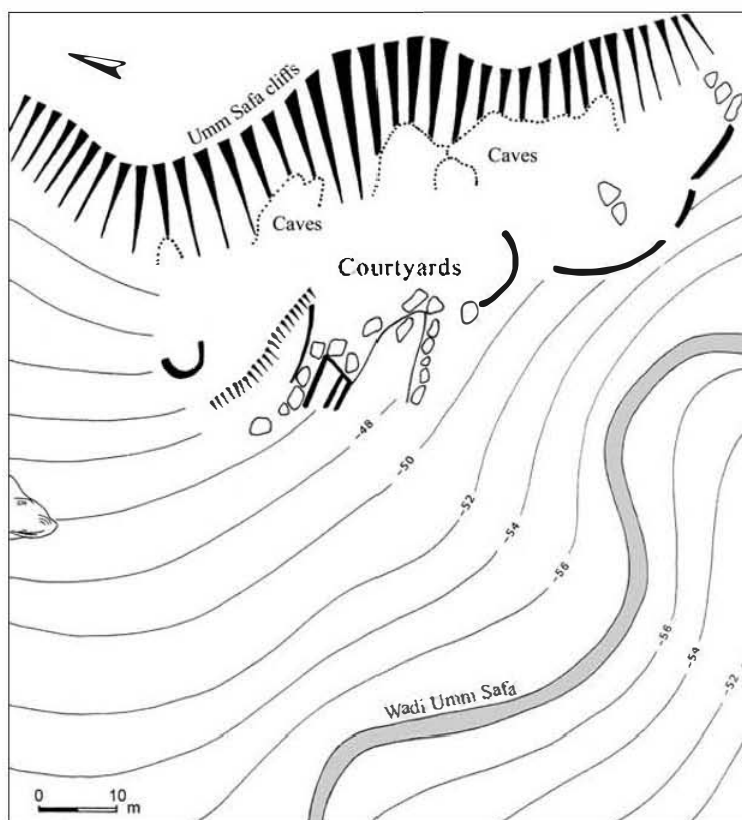
Caves in a tall cliff above the deep and narrow Wadi Umm Safa. This wadi, surrounded by cliffs, starts in the vicinity of Gittit and breaks through the rocky barrier of the deep gorge, entering from the west to the valley of Wadi Ahmar and emptying into the main wadi channel. The site is about 3.5 km south-west of the Sartaba.

Most of the caves in Wadi Umm Safa were found to be uninhabited, or were in sporadic use by shepherds. The site is composed of two sections – caves and adjacent built courtyards:

1. Three caves are located in an east-west row in the top vertical cliff on the northern bank of the wadi. They are about 30 m above the riverbed, and there is a rather steep slope at their foot. The entrance of the main (eastern) cave is about 50 m wide, and it is about 10 m deep. The cave consists of two large natural spaces connected by a tunnel or passage. A dividing wall was built in the centre of the passage at an unknown time.

Young breccia in the formation stage lies over some sections of the floor of the cave, containing Upper Palaeolithic flint items and bones. West of the main cave is another cave, about 15 m wide at its mouth and about 10 m deep. The third cave, the smallest, is directly west of this one. In all three caves the ceilings are charred, evidence of use by shepherds and others. The floors are spread with a variety of remains, both ancient and modern.

2. On the slope in front of the caves are several built courtyards. They include terrace walls with fillings in them, resting in most cases on large boulders which had rolled down the slope. The terraces served as livestock pens and also for cultivation. Flint items and other remains had accumulated in the courtyards. Apparently, these terraces were built at various times by the cave dwellers.



369. Plan of 'Urqa Umm Safa, 1995.



370. 'Urqa Umm Safa caves, looking north-west, 1997 (M. Einav).

The front part of the caves collapsed in ancient times, and large boulders have been found in the area of the courtyards. A built path leads along the south bank of Wadi Umm Safa, ascending westward from Wadi Ahmar valley to the Maale Ephraim plateau.

Pottery: Byzantine – 38%; Middle Ages – 62%.

Flint: 254 items, Upper Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Stone: Basalt lower grinding stone (Eitam 2005: 720).

Previous surveys: none.



Site 186: 19-16/04/2

ER-RUWEIHIYEH

Israel grid: 1902/1648

UTM grid: 7289/5516

Elevation: 0 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: farm

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: low hilltop

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
1.6 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
1.1 km distant

Visit: Feb. 1997; 53 sherds

A small site on a low hilltop above Wadi 'Urqa Umm Safa, located about 2 km east of Maale Ephraim, at the edge of a small plain (er-Ruweihiyeh) in which is now the Maale Ephraim industrial zone.

There are three parts to the site:

1. A structure of large fieldstones, measuring 6×4 m. The structure is in ruins, but it can be assumed from its layout that it was divided into three rooms.
2. An oval courtyard, about 10 m across, abutting the structure to the east. The yard is encircled by a low wall one stone thick.
3. East of the former is an oval threshing floor, about 10 m across, surrounded by a stone wall, with a cleared rocky surface at its centre.

The place appears to have been a small farm or a seasonal site for cereal-growing.

Pottery: Iron II – 50%; Early Roman – 50%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 186 (1): 19-16/04/1

MAALE EPHRAIM (EAST)

Israel grid: 1903/1642

UTM grid: 7290/5511

Elevation: 50 m a.s.l., 10 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: structure

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: low hilltop

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein es-Sukhun (175),
1.7 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 1.1 km
distant

A small site on a low hilltop, located about 2 km east of Maale Ephraim, at the edge of a small plain in which is now the Maale Ephraim industrial zone.

A salvage excavation on the hilltop (Peleg 2002) during the preparations for the enlargement of the industrial zone, revealed the remains of a two-room structure built of large uncut stones, and an adjacent courtyard. The western room, 5.3×4.7 m in size, had a beaten earth and floor paved with small pebbles. The smaller eastern room, 4.9×2.5 m in size, used the bedrock as a living surface, and was possibly used for storage. The yard, 19×12 m, also used the bedrock as living surface.

The excavator suggests that this was probably a field structure or a seasonal resting place for shepherds. Another possibility is that this was a small family farmstead from the Hellenistic period.

A tumulus was also found in a valley 400 m east of the excavated structure.

Pottery: Hellenistic – 100%.

Previous surveys: none.

Site 187: 19-16/14/4
WADI SADI (2)

Israel grid: 1911/1648	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7297/5517	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 150 m b.s.l., 50 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place.	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 1.3 km distant
Site type: enclosures and structures	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 300 m distant
Area: 10 dunams (1 ha)	Visit: Dec. 1997; 100 sherds
Topography: shoulder above wadi	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A large site on an isolated shoulder within the 'Urqan Umm Safa cliffs south of the deep riverbed of Wadi Sadi. The length of the shoulder is about 300-400 m, and its width up to the channel is about 50 m. The site, which is 3.2 km north of Fasa'el, is well concealed in the channel. Around the entire shoulder area are scattered large boulders, which rolled down from the southern cliff, and the structures and courtyards benefit from their support.

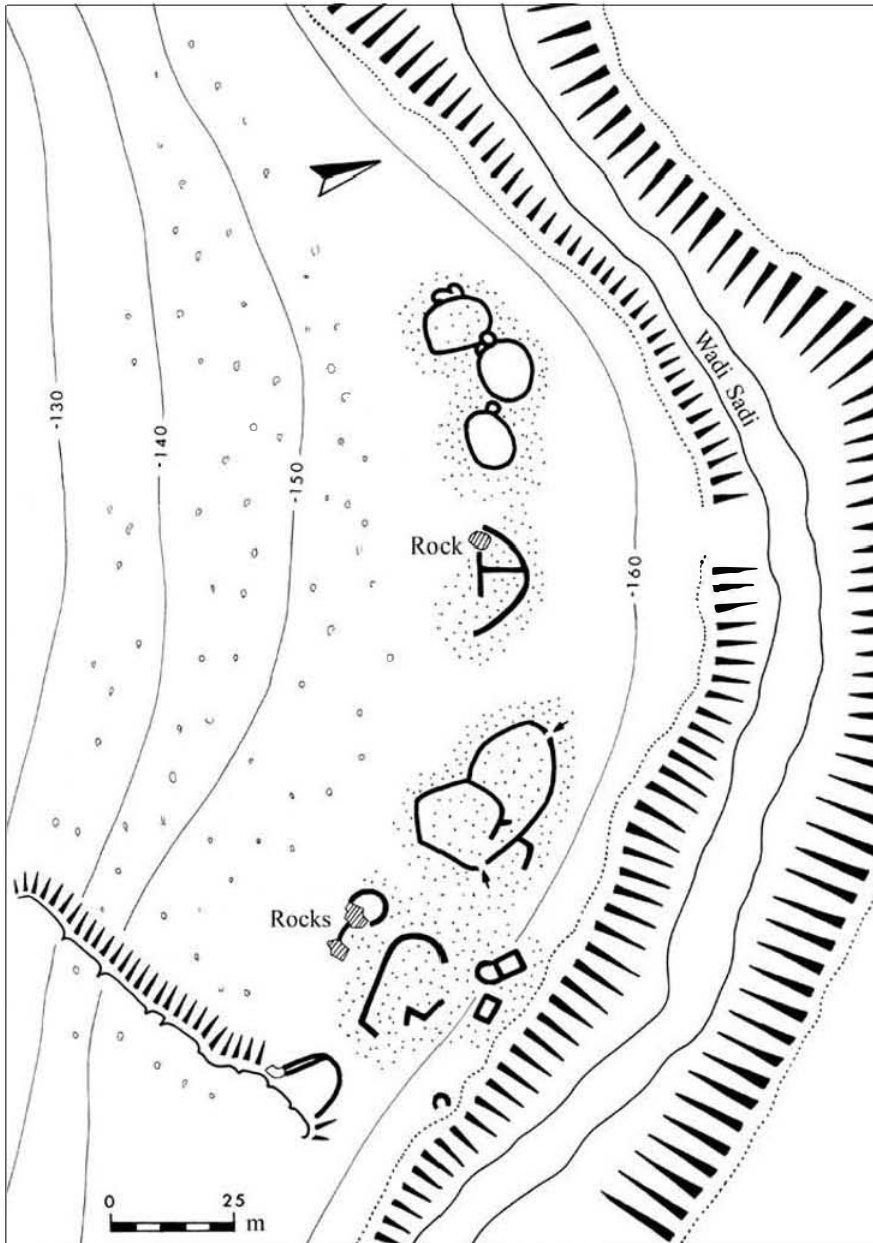
The site contains a significant number of ancient and new enclosures, and many other structures *in situ*. There are two significant stages:

Later stage. Seven courtyards averaging about 20 m in diameter have been found along a stretch of about 250 m west to east. They are spread over the shoulder and are built of medium-sized stones extracted from the ancient settlement. The yards are divided into four parts from west to east:

1. Three adjacent oval yards, 10×15 m, with square or rounded structures attached to the outside. Presumably, there was a linkage, perhaps familial, between the inhabitants of the enclosure.
2. At the centre of the site is a semicircular enclosure, divided at its centre and reaching to a large boulder.
3. A double enclosure, with maximum diameter of 35 m. The entrance is from the east, and attached to it are the remains of a broad room. Inside, between the two enclosures, is a passage.
4. An incomplete or ruined enclosure with two rectangular structures next to it: one has a single room and the other has two rooms. Above them, up the slope, are two large boulders with a wall between them, presumably intended as defence for the constructed complex.

All these courtyards are built from walls one or two stones thick, currently standing up to about 1 m. It is apparent that they are being maintained by the

Bedouin. The construction is in two stages: large stones at the base and smaller ones above and for repairs. We assume that this entire complex represents the 'new' site, apparently built in the Middle Ages and Ottoman period, and in use until now.



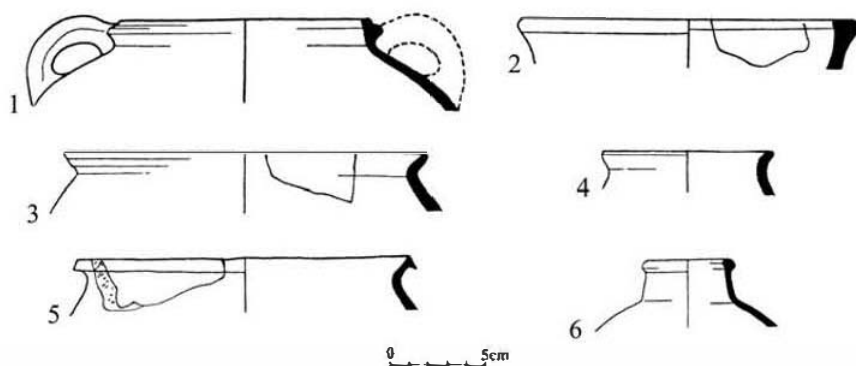
371. Plan of Wadi Sadi (2), 1995.

Early stage (IA to the Roman period). Structures and yards built of large stones in dry construction. Most of the early phase structures are on the eastern narrow side of the shoulder, yet probably there were also some on the western side. They survived in the form of wall sections. Most of their stones were taken for the construction of the 'new' site. An earlier phase exists in most of the walls of the later phase.

The location of the settlement is significant, being difficult to approach, between a cliff and the deep Wadi Sadi riverbed.



372. Aerial view of Wadi Sadi (2), looking south, 2013 (A. Solomon).



373. Pottery from Wadi Sadi (2): 1. CP, brn, Ir II; 2. Bowl, lt brn, Ir II; 3. 5. CPs, dk brn, Ir I; 4, 6. Jugs, brn, LR.

The site typifies mainly IA 'shoulder settlements' situated along Wadi Ahmar.

Pottery: Iron I – 12%; Iron II – 20%; Late Roman – 40%; Middle Ages – 12%; Ottoman – 6%; Modern – 10%.

Flint: 2 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 188: 19-16/14/5

WADI SADI (3)

Israel grid: 1913/1649

UTM grid: 7299/5517

Elevation: 150 m b.s.l., 70 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosures

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: shoulder above wadi

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.2 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
next to the site

Visit: Dec. 1995; 25 sherds

Enclosures on a high shoulder at the confluence of Wadis Sadi, Ahmar and Zaqaska, about 3.5 km south-west of the Sartaba. The place is close to the outlet of Wadi Sadi from the cavern to the valley of Wadi Ahmar.

Two enclosures were found close together on the steep rocky slope at the north. The eastern one, built of medium-sized stones, is 12 m in diameter. In front are reinforcement walls or structural remains. The western one is almost totally ruined, and seems to have been similar in construction and dimensions to the eastern one.

Only a few sherds and flint items were found at the site, but they are diagnostic of the Chalcolithic Period.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 80%; Late Roman – 20%.

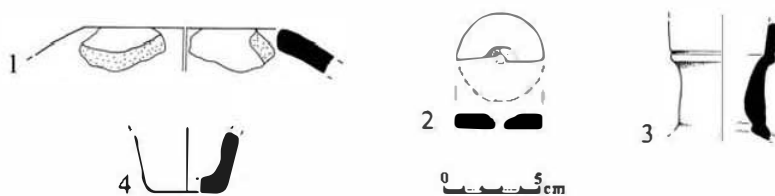
Flint: 8 items, Chalcolithic, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 76.



374. Wadi Sadi (3), view to the west, 1996 (M. Einav).



375. Pottery from Wadi Sadi (3): 1. HM, buff, Chal; 2. Drilled clay weight, pk, Chal; 3. Jar, LR; 4. Base of bowl, buff, Chal.

Site 189: 19-16/14/2
WADI SADI (1)

Israel grid: 1912/1647	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7299/5515	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 160 m b.s.l., 50 m b.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 1.3 km distant
Site type: enclosure and encampment	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), next to the site
Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)	Visits: Dec. 1995, Oct. 2003; 30 sherds
Topography: shoulder above wadi	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A site on the shoulder of Wadi Ahmar, south of its confluence with Wadi Sadi. The narrow shoulder is between the Wadi Ahmar channel in the east (here about 40 m wide) and the steep rocky slope in the west, rising straight upwards above the site. It is about 3.5 km north of Fasa'el.

The shoulder is about 300 m long and about 80 m wide, isolated by the deep riverbed of Wadi Ahmar, encircling it in the north and east. The principal feature of the site is an oval enclosure, measuring 44 m by 25 m. The wall of the enclosure is well built of two rows of large stones, in a style known from other IA I enclosures. There is an opening or breach in the eastern side, but it is uncertain if this was the entrance. Near the main enclosure on the northern slope was another enclosure, possibly built to support the main one. It is also well built and is slightly lower than the large enclosure. Near the main enclosure are several structures. By the narrower southern end are two single-roomed structures connected by a wall. They are also well built of large stones. Another broad room is attached inside at right angles to the wall of the west enclosure.

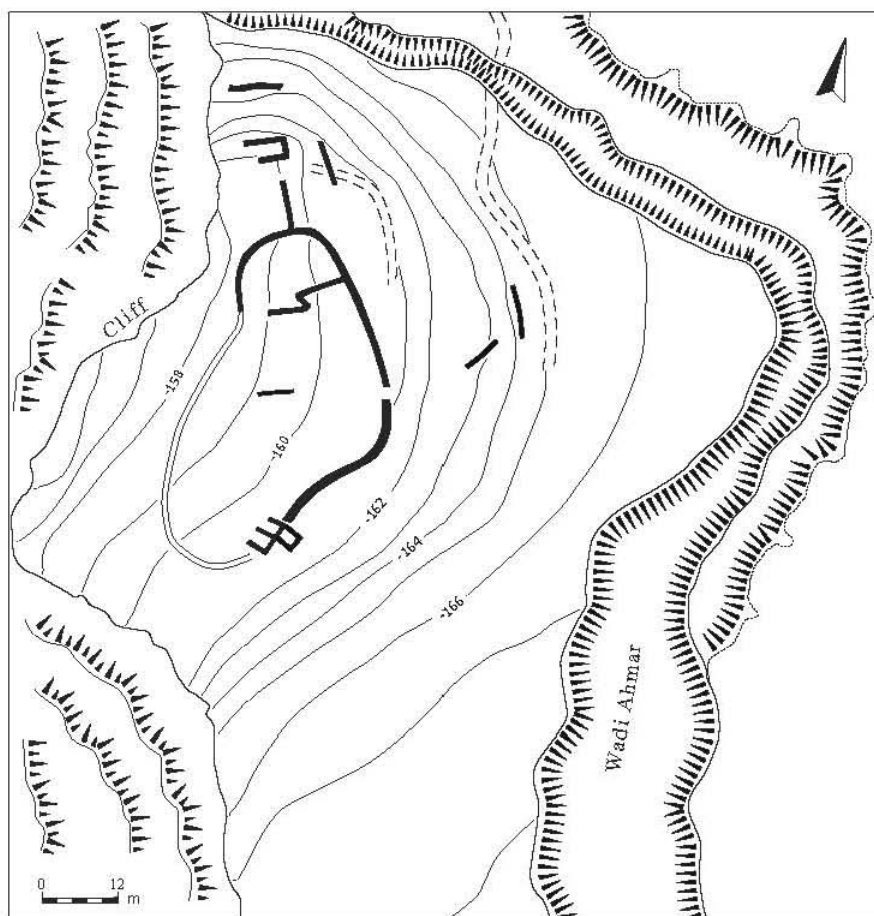
There are also several structures attached to the enclosure. Slightly north of the 'supporting enclosure' is a well built broad room, and south of it are two or three other smaller structures, also well built of local square stones. There is a slight scatter of IA sherds in and around the enclosure.

On the shoulder, in the south, are the remains of a Bedouin encampment and several small square structures, similar to those in the enclosure.

Pottery: Iron I – 70%; Iron II – 30%.

Flint: 53 items, Iron Age, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



376. Plan of Wadi Sadi (1), 2003.



377. Wadi Sadi (1), looking south, 2003 (M. Einav).

Site 190: 19-16/14/6

WADI AHMAR (5)

Israel grid: 1916/1645

UTM grid: 7302/5514

Elevation: 160 m b.s.l., 5 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: cemetery

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: hilltop within valley

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.5 km distantRoad: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
next to the site

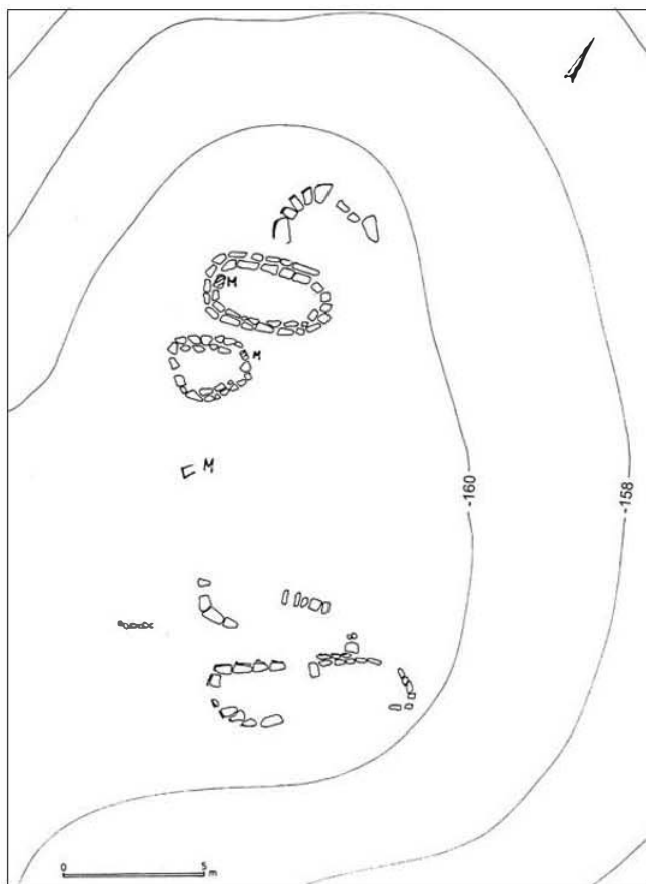
Visits: Feb. 1996 and more; 10 sherds

A cemetery on a hilltop in the southern part of the Wadi Ahmar valley, close to the unpaved road from the Jordan Valley Monument which crosses the Wadi Ahmar valley and ascends north to the Sartaba. There is a good view from the hilltop to Wadi Ahmar and its tributaries.

The low hilltop is prominent and easily visible from all over the valley. Five oval structures built of large stones, measuring about 4×2 m, were found on it. According to their measurements and design they appear to be constructed tombs. On both sides of the structures there is an upright standing monolith (marked M in the plan). There are remains of walls here and there.

The dating of the site is not certain. The construction appears to be ancient, but the sherds are Roman. It is also obvious that this is not a modern Bedouin cemetery, because Bedouin burial customs are quite different.

Pottery: Late Roman (?) – 100%.**Flint:** 13 items, see Appendix A.**Previous surveys:** none.



378. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (5), 1996.



379. The hilltop of Wadi Ahmar (5), view to the north-west, 2003 (M. Einav).

Site 19: 19-16/14/3

WADI AHMAR (6)

Israel grid: 1918/1648	Soil quality: 3
UTM grid: 7304/5516	Cultivation: none
Elevation: 135 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.	Cisterns: none
Name: nearest place	Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176), 1.3 km distant
Site type: structures	Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), 500 m distant
Area: 1.5 dunams (1500 sq. m)	Visit: Feb. 1996, 2015; 70 sherds
Topography: valley	
Rock type: Avdat Group	
Soil type: stony-desert	

A site in the centre of the Wadi Ahmar valley, about 3 km north of Fasa'el. Next to it is the unpaved road from the Jordan Valley road which ascends to the Sartaba, and about 20 m east of it is a shallow stream.

In the centre of the site is an irregular enclosure, measuring about 25×20 m, the western part of which has not been preserved. The enclosing wall is built of one or two rows of large stones. From the construction of the enclosure it is apparent that it has undergone various stages of construction and demolition.

The enclosure is trapezoidal, and its southern corner is an acute angle. The entrance was in the north-eastern, slightly rounded, corner. Part of a circular, practically ruined, ancient dyke is attached to the abruptly terminated western end. A wall 8 m long, which was perhaps an element of an inner structure, projects into the enclosed area from the east. Within the enclosure space is a variety of scanty remains of walls.

Attached to the outside of the north wall is a four-roomed structure, only the foundation of which, built of medium-sized stones, survive. Thin walls project eastward from the enclosure.

About 40 m farther west is a round tower, 6 m in diameter.

There are additional structural remains, whose relation to the main enclosure is unclear. There is a thin scatter of sherds and flint items all over the site.

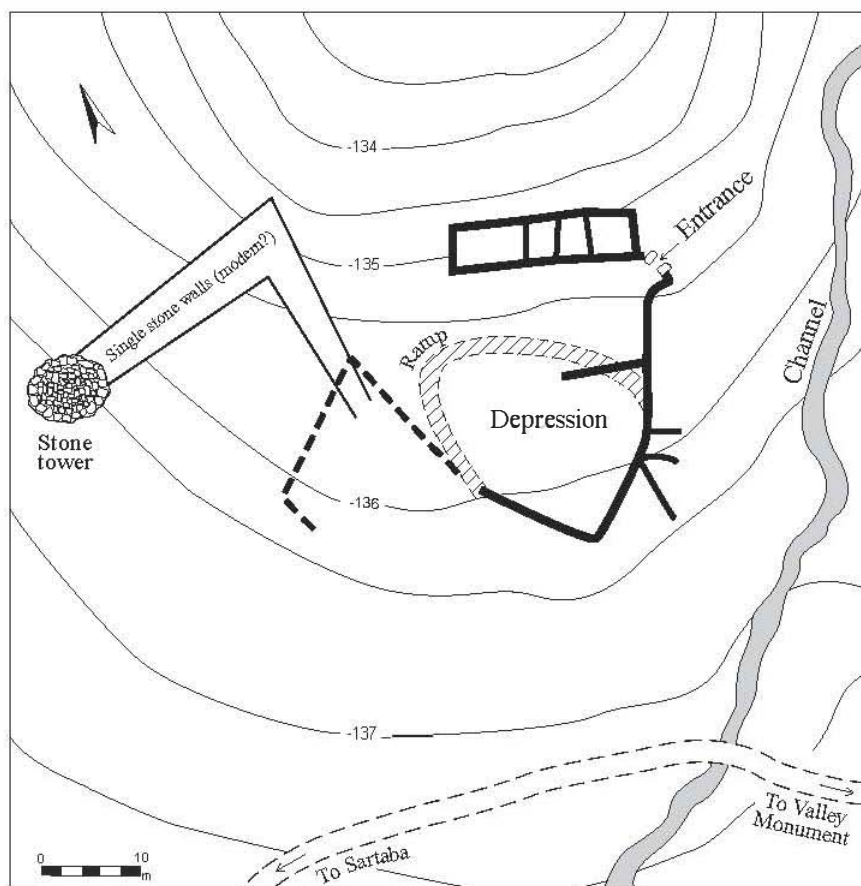
This site is unique in the Wadi Ahmar vicinity, because of the combination of the extraordinary shape of the enclosure, irregular rather than circular, and the presence of dwellings.

Pottery: Iron II – 22%; Late Roman – 41%; Byzantine – 25%; Middle Ages – 12%.

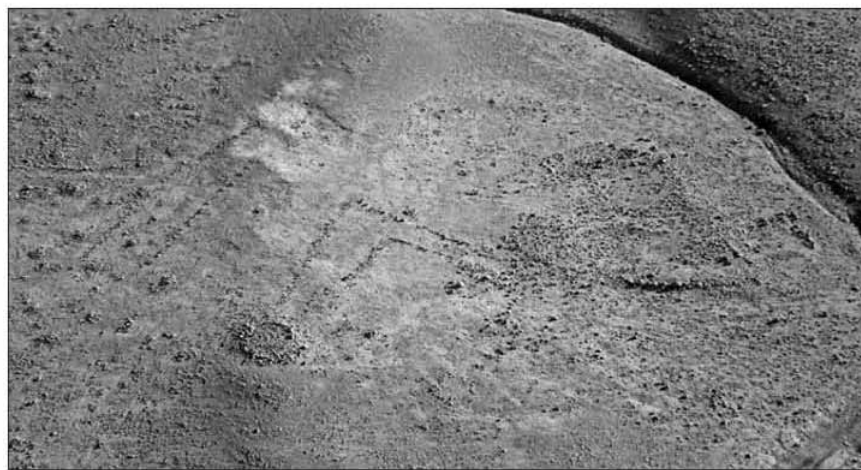
Flint: 5 items, see Appendix A.

Stone: Basalt mano (Eitam 2005: 720).

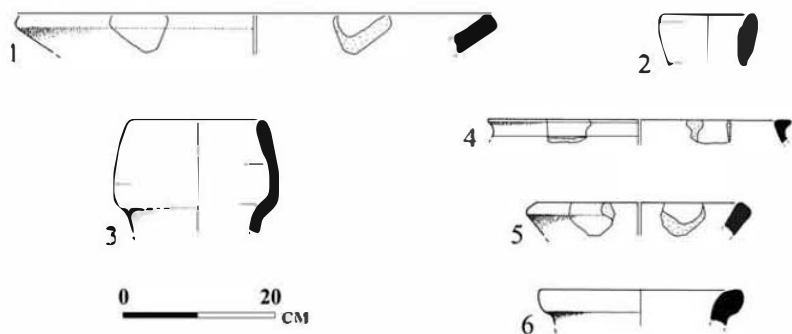
Previous surveys: none.



380. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (6), 2014.



381. Aerial view of Wadi Ahmar (6), looking north-east, 2013 (A. Solomon).



382. Pottery from Wadi Ahmar (6): 1. Bowl, lt brn, LR; 2-3. Jugs, buff, Rom; 4. Bowl, brn, Ir II; 5-6. Jars, lt brn, Rom.



Site 192: 19-16/14/1

E.P. -167

Israel grid: 1919/1643

UTM grid: 7305/5511

Elevation: 160 m b.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: large

Area: 12 dunams (1.2 ha)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
2 km distant

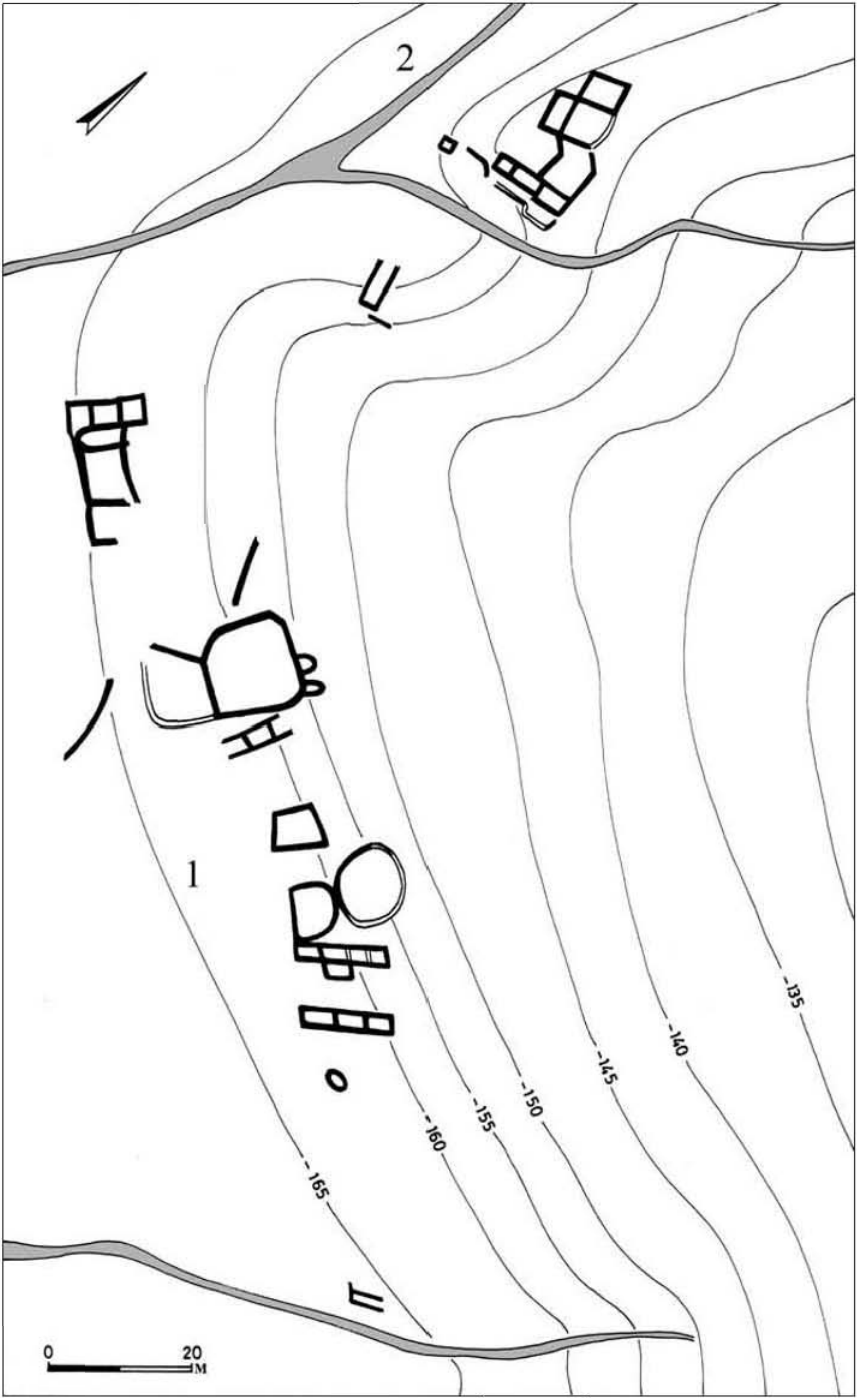
Road: Fasa'el-Tana (C40),
500 m distant

Visits: Dec. 1995 and many more,
excavation 2007, 2014;
85 sherds

A large site in the eastern margins of the Wadi Ahmar valley, about 2.5 km north of Fasa'el. The unpaved road from the Jordan Valley Monument that ascends north-east to the Sartaba passes close to its edge.

The site structures are on a moderate slope and in the plain, on the lower slopes of the Sartaba range. The structures can be divided into two groups:

1. In the lower part of the slope there are four elongated rooms of the 'chain type' and courtyards and enclosures next to them. The houses are about 15 m long, divided into three or four rooms. Two of the nearer structures on the east are at the same orientation, 7 m apart. North of them is a group of three enclosures: one circular, 10 m in diameter, the second



383. Plan of E.P. -167,1995.

trapezoidal, 8×7 m, and the third one D-shaped, 8 m in diameter. There is another incomplete 'chain-like' structure 10 m further west, and next to it is a large double enclosure: the northern part is about 13 m in diameter, and the southern one is 10 m. Two small semicircular structures are attached to the northern side of the courtyard. About 35 m west of the former is another three-roomed structure, and a double square courtyard is attached to it to the east. The houses are arranged in a strip along the valley border. The construction is good, of large and medium-sized local stones. The bottom courses of the walls survive: in parts of the structures the plan is clear, in others it is not.

2. This part of the site lies in the plain, about 60 m north of the first one, and across a small ravine which descends to the valley. The tip of the spur prevents eye contact between the two parts. A complex of houses and courtyards was found in this part, including a three-roomed 'chain' structure. Attached north of it is a complex of four square spaces measuring 8–10 m each. Close to the above complex are remains of walls and structures; evidence that the complex was larger in the past. Close by to the south of the small ravine are remains of another structure.

In the survey there was an extremely poor find of ceramic body fragments, none datable. The situation with flint items was similar: the finds are particularly sparse, and secondary usage is apparent. Only after the 2007 excavation at the site (see Appendix D) was an Intermediate Bronze Age date of the site determined.



384. Aerial view of E.P. -167, looking north-east, 2013 (A. Solomon).

The site at E.P. -167 is an example of a repeated phenomenon in the Wadi Ahmar area. The architecture is well developed; the construction is of good quality, and so is the pattern of the structures. It is apparent that much had been invested in the structures and the site was built for dwelling. However, the small find is extremely poor, due to seasonality or other unknown reasons.

See Appendix D for a detailed report of the excavations at the site.

Pottery: Intermediate Bronze – 80%; unidentified – 20%.

Flint: 20 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 79.



Site 193: 19-16/14/8

WADI AHMAR (7)

Israel grid: 1918/1641

UTM grid: 7304/5510

Elevation: 160 m b.s.l., 0 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosures

Area: 5 dunams (5000 sq. m)

Topography: flood plain

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: marl

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.9 km distant

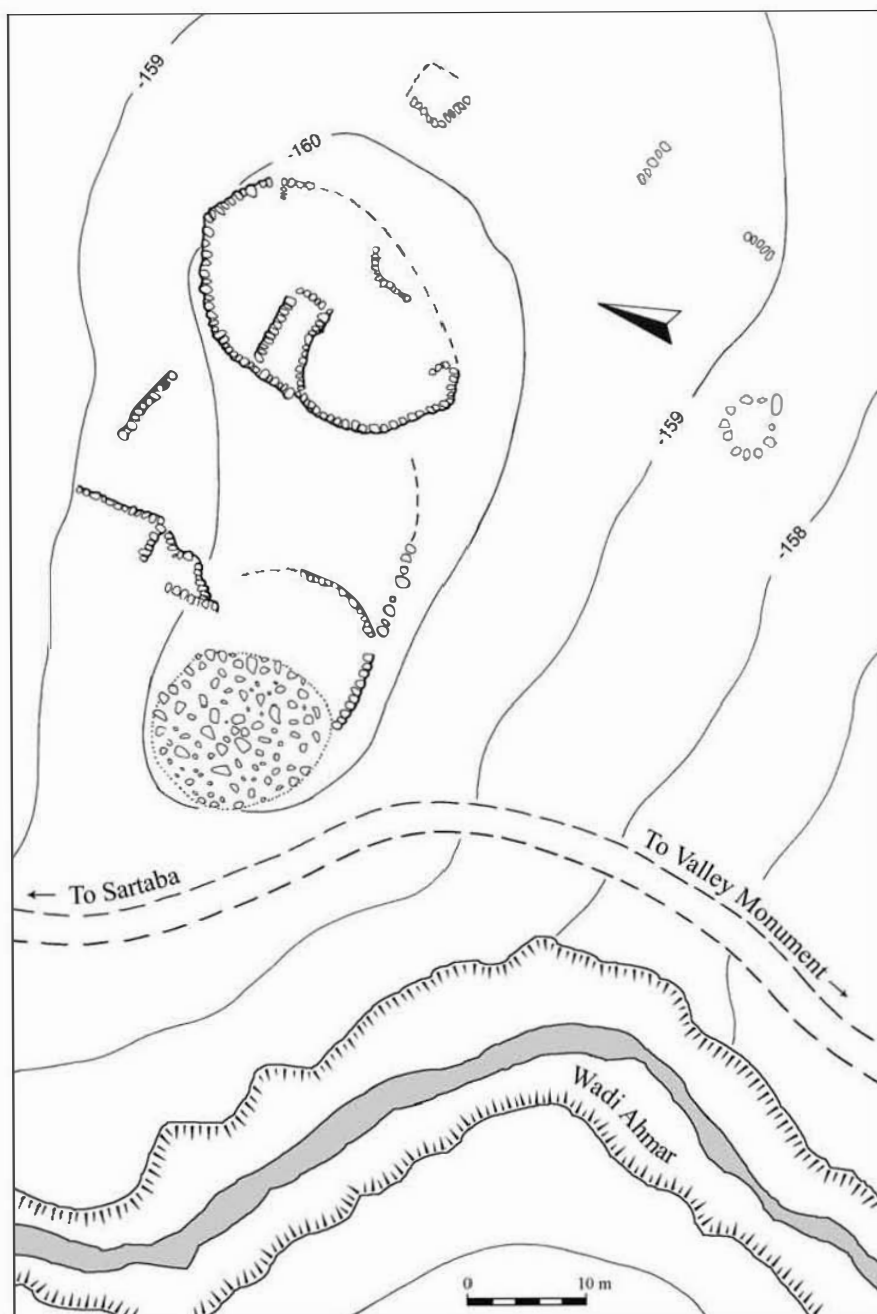
Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
300 m distant

Visit: Nov. 2002 and more; 30 sherds

Enclosures and structures in the southern part of the Wadi Ahmar valley. The road ascending to the Sartaba passes close to the east of the site. West of the site is the broad deep riverbed of Wadi Ahmar. The site is next to the small hill upon which is a cemetery (Wadi Ahmar (5) – Site 190) and the IBA village at E.P. -167 (Site 172).

In the western part of the site are the remains of a large round structure about 15 m in diameter. The round shape could be either the original form or a result of its demolition. At the centre there is a cluster of large stones, perhaps the remains of the central building. A curved wall of medium-sized stones projects eastward from the structure, forming a round enclosure about 20 m in diameter attached to it. The yard wall extends east, encircling a shallow hollow, apparently the result of erosion. This was perhaps also a round courtyard.

Further east, over a broad hillock in the plain, is an oval yard, measuring



385. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (7), 2001.

25×15 m. Inside it is an irregular room, about 8 m long, abutting the courtyard wall. About 12 m further east are remains of a square structure, and about 25 m south is a stone circle. Remains of other structures are scattered around the principal enclosures, with round and square structures in them. Only a few body sherds and several rims were gathered.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 100%.

Flint: 65 items, Chalcolithic, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 78.



Site 194: 19-16/13/2

WADI AHMAR (2)

Israel grid: 1913/1633

UTM grid: 7300/5502

Elevation: 170 m b.s.l., 50 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: large

Area: 25 dunams (2.5 ha)

Topography: broad shoulder above
wadi

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Fasa'el pool (171),
2 km distant

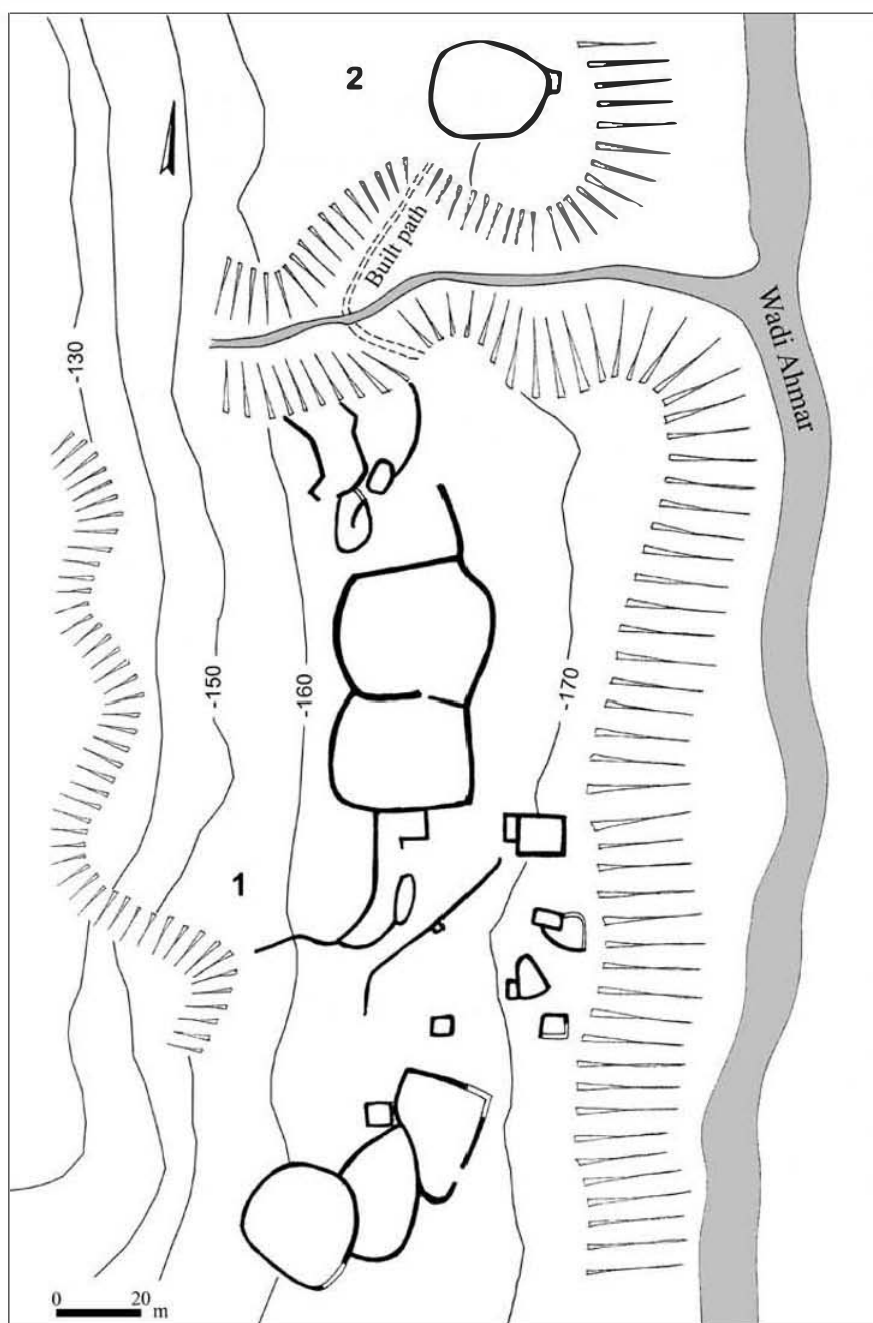
Road: Fasa'el–Ṭana (C40),
1 km distant

Visits: Nov. 1995, 2002-2003 and
others; 120 sherds

A large site of enclosures and structures in the western border of the Wadi Ahmar valley, on a long and broad shoulder west of the deep channel of the wadi, between it and the slope, and the cliffs rising to the west to the Umm Safa summit. Another part of the site is north of the stream coming from the hills. The site is about 3.2 km east of Maale Ephraim, and about 1.5 km north of Fasa'el.

There are two groups of enclosures in the site, with dwelling houses between them, and a solitary enclosure in the north. The description will deal with the two groups which are on the main shoulder – the western one and the single enclosure on the northern shoulder. The parts are linked by a constructed pathway.

1. The southern shoulder. This is about 230 m long, and about 40 m wide between the wadi and the slopes. There are two clusters of enclosures on



386. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (2), 1995.

it, with other structures between and near them. The southern cluster consists of three enclosures: two round or oval, and a lower rectangular one, measuring about 25×20 m, with an opening in the eastern side. Next to the join of this enclosure to the oval enclosure above it is a square structure, measuring 5×5 m.

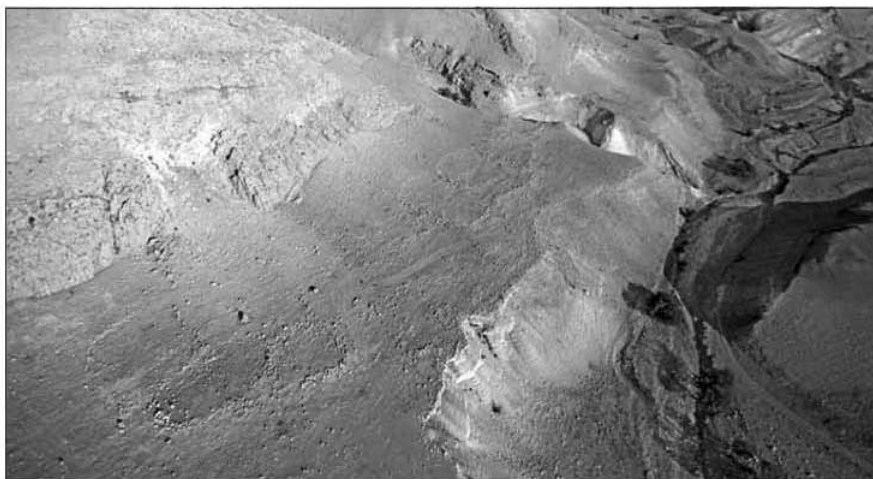
The northern cluster includes a pair of adjacent large circular enclosures, both about 30 m in diameter. There is an opening in their common wall. Long walls at the north and south connect to the two enclosures. Some parts of structures are connected to these walls.

Between the two enclosure clusters are five square structures with small yards attached to some of them. To the largest northernmost of them reaches a 50 m-long, wall which possibly separated the two clusters of enclosures in the past.

North of the pair of large enclosures are more irregular oval structures with walls leading from them down to the stream coming from the mountains to Wadi Ahmar.

2. The north shoulder. This is a single irregular enclosure, about 30 m in diameter, abutted by a small structure.

The enclosures are relatively well built of large fieldstones. The walls are built of stones in one or two rows. In addition to the main structures described above, other constructions are visible in the area. They include various installations, rock-cut and lined cisterns, remains of walls, etc.



387. An aerial view to the north of Wadi Ahmar (2), 2013 (A. Solomon).

This is possibly the site of 'Arkān es-Sūwāneh (Bar-Adon 1972: site 11), described as: "enclosures, structures and caves, spread over an area of 200×70 m; a structure at the top of a hillock, surrounded by rectangular enclosures built of large stones. There are more enclosures and structures south and north", but the coordinates and description do not fit precisely.

Judging by the construction style, at least some of the enclosures and structures were apparently erected in the IA I.

According to the site dimensions and complexity, the place served as one of the main settlements in the region during the IA. Up to 100 inhabitants could have dwelt here in permanent structures, particularly in the IA and Roman periods.

Pottery: Iron I – 6%; Iron II – 54%; Hellenistic – 1%; Late Roman – 35%; Middle Ages – 2%; unidentified – 4%.

Flint: 3 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: Bar-Adon 1972: site 11.

Additional Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 74.



Site 195: 19-16/13/1

'URQAN ER-RUB

Israel grid: 1916/1634

UTM grid: 7303/5503

Elevation: 180 m b.s.l., 40 m b.s.a.

Name: on map, but not from a historical source

Site type: large

Area: 15 dunams (1.5 ha)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 4

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Fasa'el pool (171), 2.2 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40), next to the site

Visits: Nov. 1995 and later; 145 sherds

A large and complex site in the low southern margins of the 'Urqan er-Rub ridge, close to Wadi Ahmar. The ridge rises in the central part of the Wadi Ahmar valley, dividing it into northern and eastern parts. In the upper part of the site are cliffs and caves. The site is about 2 km north of Fasa'el.

The place has three main parts:

1. In the high cliff there are entrances to four caves (in order of 1 to 4 from east to west), with courtyards and enclosures built of large stones in the

nearby steep slope in front. The width of the cave entrances varies from 4 to 8 m, and they are 10–15 m deep. Two main courtyards have been distinguished: the larger of the two is in front of caves 3 and 4, the second one west of the first has no cave behind it. The total length of the yards is about 40 m, and between and inside them are many boulders which have rolled down in the past to rest on the slope. Another smaller enclosure is on the slope below caves 3 and 4.

2. The eastern site, on a flat shoulder, is about 120 m long and about 40 m wide. Contained in it are at least six enclosures or parts of enclosures, which were in use during various periods. In the east were found remains of an enclosing wall on the slope descending from north to south, and ending with a round enclosure about 20 m in diameter. West of it is a large area with remains of an enclosure. Further west there are two or three additional interconnecting enclosures. The first one is unfinished, and west of it is an oval enclosure, 25 m in across, and further on are two small enclosures inside a built frame attached to the round enclosure. North of these are the remains of two small rectangular structures. Further to the north-west are the remains of two large enclosures which have been dismantled.

The whole area looks like a mixture of various elements of enclosures and structures, which have undergone phases of dismantling and rebuilding over periods of time. It is difficult to date all of them, yet there is sort of 'horizontal stratigraphy': element by element instead of one above another. Differences in construction quality between the various enclosures should be noted: from meticulous construction with large stones to haphazard laying of medium-sized stones.

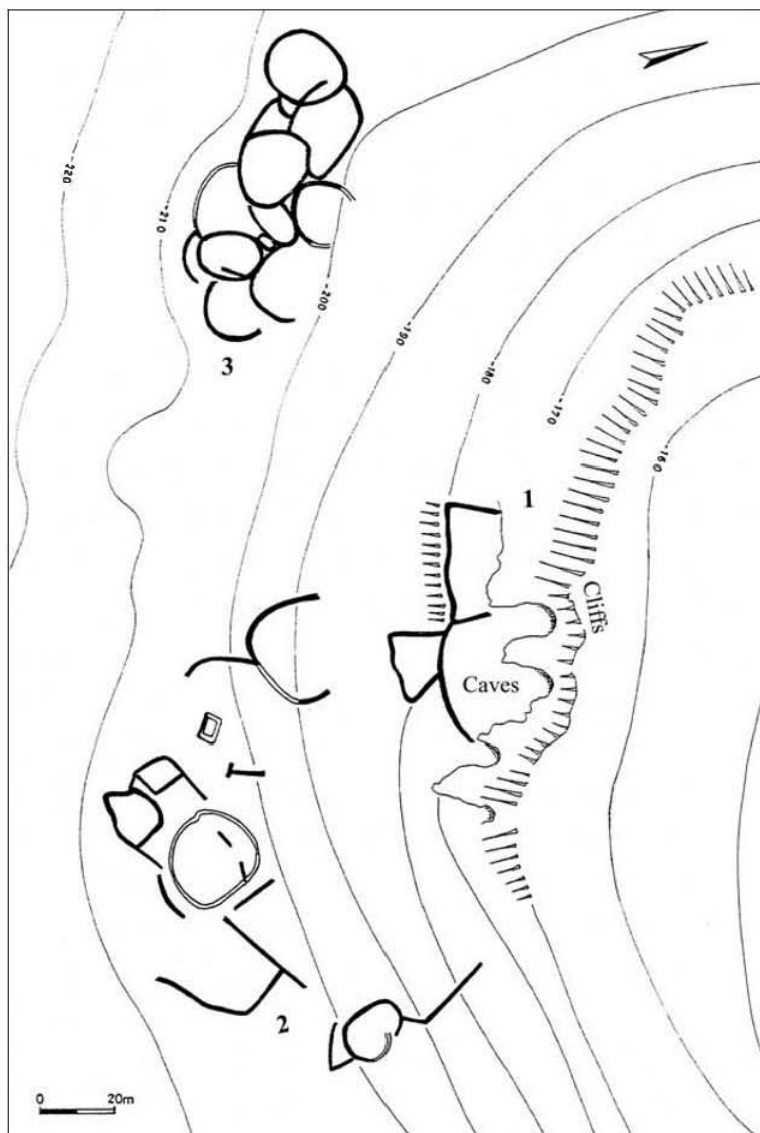
3. About 100 m to the west, beyond the upper sections of two deep channels, is the western part of the site. This is an assemblage of nine round enclosures, attached to each other and built in an coordinated fashion. The construction of large boulders is good, similar to the construction of the enclosures in the eastern part of the site. However, there are clear differences in layout between the two parts: the western one was not dismantled, and its construction is far more homogeneous than that of the eastern one. It should be noted that the number of sherds in this area is particularly low.

Over parts of the site is a modern Bedouin cemetery, with graves marked by stones. On the summit of the hill above the cliffs ('Urqan er-Rub, E.P. -231) is a heap of stones, 8 m in diameter and about 1.5 m high. Currently there is an abandoned army position in it, and Roman sherds were collected in its vicinity.

For prehistoric excavations carried north of 'Urqan er-Rub, see Bibliography.

Pottery: Chalcolithic – 34%; Intermediate Bronze – 5%; Late Roman – 26%; Byzantine – 11%; Middle Ages (?) – 9%; Modern – 15%.

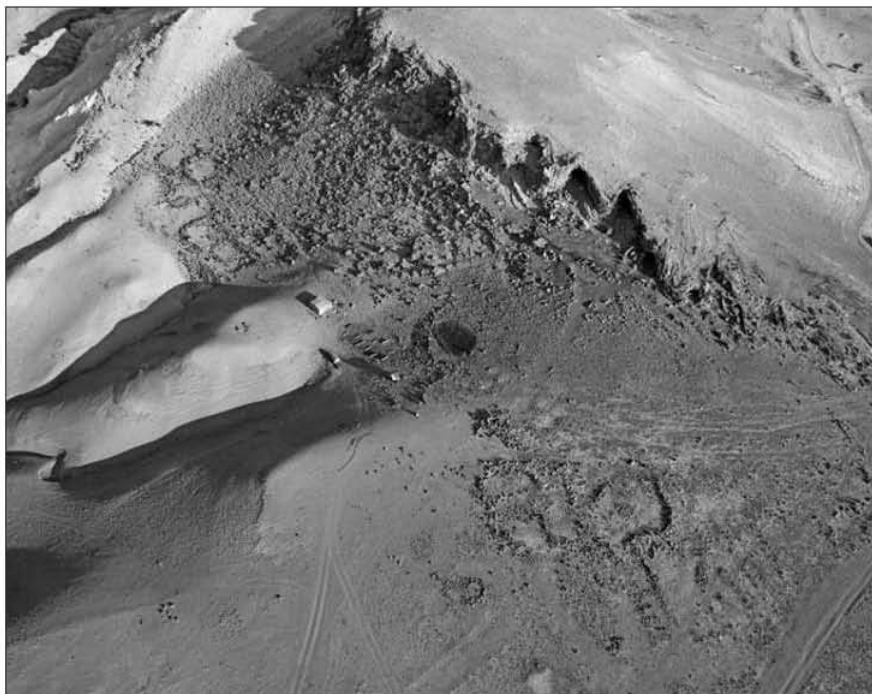
Flint: Epipalaeolithic, Kebaran phase (based upon previous excavations north of the site – see bibliography).



388. Plan of 'Urqan er-Rub, 1995.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Hovers and Bar-Yosef 1987; Hovers 1993; Bar 2014a: site 81.



389. Aerial view to the north of 'Urqan er-Rub, 2013 (A. Solomon).



Site 196; 19-16/23/2

E.P. -145

Israel grid: 1924/1639

UTM grid: 7310/5508

Elevation: 145 m b.s.l., 100 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: small

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: spur at valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
2.2 km distant

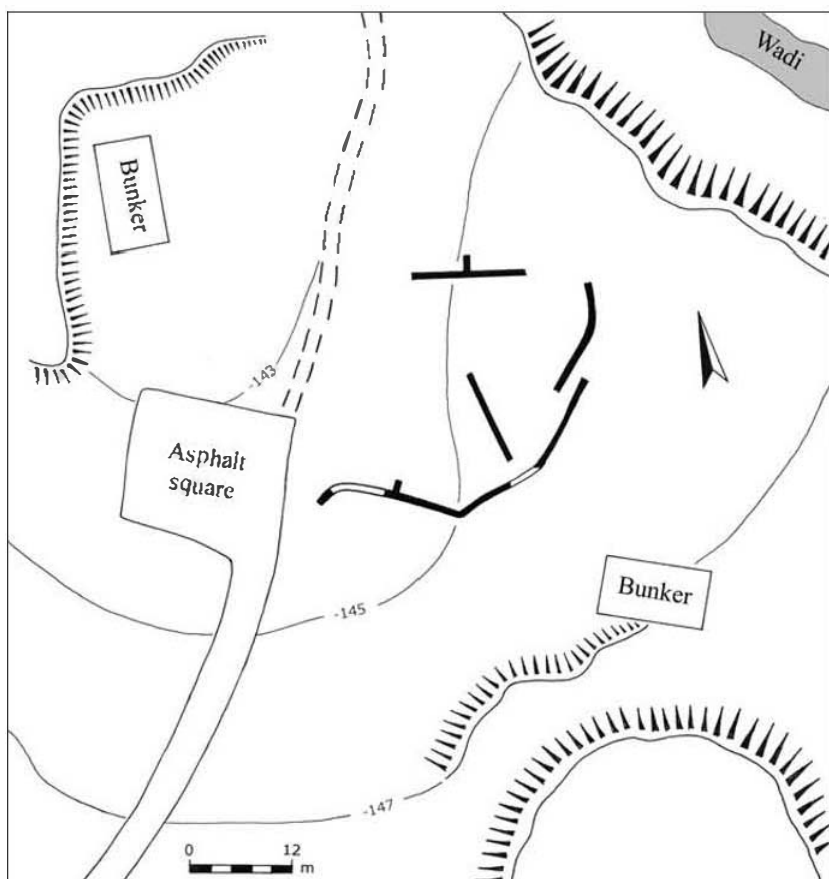
Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
500 m distant

Visits: April 2002, 2010; 74 sherds

A small site on a low spur projecting from the southern ridge of the Sartaba into the Wadi Ahmar valley. The spur is isolated by fairly deep wadis east and west; a military bunker (now deserted) was established on it and almost totally destroyed the site.

At the site's centre, between two concrete bunkers, was found a wide surface, about 100×50 m with construction remains – walls of medium-sized stones and pebbles. Most of the walls were built two stones thick (about 50 cm): perhaps a large structure with several rooms stood here.

According the numerous periods (according to the pottery finds) and the construction remains, there is no doubt that it was a multi-period site. It is very probable that this was a site of importance in the Wadi Ahmar valley in the later periods (Roman and onward).



390. Plan of E.P. -145, 2002. The site has been traced inside a deserted military stronghold, which destroyed most of the archaeological site.

Pottery: Iron I – 9%; Iron II – 9%; Hellenistic – 11%; Late Roman – 30%; Byzantine – 33%; Middle Ages – 2%; unidentified – 6%.

Previous surveys: none.

Bibliography: Bar 2014a: site 80.



Site 197: 19-16/33/1

'URQAN EL-MASTARAH

Israel grid: 1932/1639

UTM grid: 7318/5508

Elevation: 25 m b.s.l., 60 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosure

Area: 1 dunam (1000 sq. m)

Topography: high spur

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
2.5 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
1 km distant

Visit: March 1996; 40 sherds

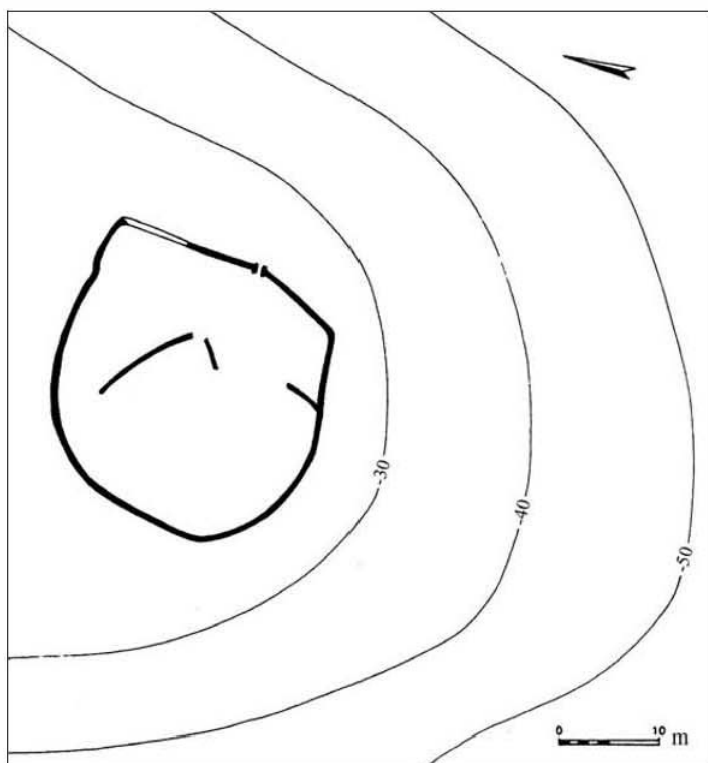
An enclosure in a saddle on a high spur in the southern part of the Sartaba range, about 1.5 km west of Yafit. The high extensions of the Sartaba plateau are outstanding for their intensive cover of large- and medium-sized stones, creating a unique landscape. From the site is a good view to the valley of Wadi Ahmar.

The enclosure is irregular in form: the eastern wall is straight, 23 m long, with constructed entrance, 70 cm wide, between two standing monoliths. From this wall a curved wall, about 36 m maximum diameter, extends west, with both ends meeting the straight wall, forming the enclosure. The encircling wall is built of large, well laid stones; but the construction differs from that of typical IA I enclosures.

Inside the enclosure were found remains of dry-built walls of medium-sized stones. One projects from the inside of the enclosure wall, and another wall is round, hinting at another or more ancient enclosure.

Of the numerous IA enclosures in the Jordan Valley and around, this site is unique in its lofty and isolated location. Its date is not obvious; however, it is certain that it was in use mainly in the Roman period.

Judging by the flint finds, a Middle and Upper Palaeolithic site is also located nearby.



391. Plan of 'Urqan el-Mastarah, 1996.



392. The enclosure of 'Urqan el-Mastarah, looking north-west (M. Einav).

Pottery: Iron I (?) – 5%; Iron II – 8%; Late Roman – 87%.

Flint: 65 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 198: 19-16/23/1

TAL'AT 'AMREH (1)

Israel grid: 1929/1632

UTM grid: 7315/5500

Elevation: 175 m b.s.l., 0 m b.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: small settlement

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: silt

Soil quality: 5

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Fasa'el pool (171),
2.8 km distant

Road: Fasa'el–Tana (C40),
1 km distant

Visit: Nov. 1995; 46 sherds

A site in the north-eastern margins of the Wadi Ahmar valley, about 4 km south-south-west of the Sartaba. Near it, about 300 m to the south, passes the narrow asphalt road from the Jordan Valley Monument. In this region the many streams descending from the Sartaba plateau (named Tal'at 'Amreh by the locals) cut through the plain.

In the site, which is badly disturbed, were found the remains of 10 small structures built of large stones, whose outlines have been blurred by modern destruction.

One of the structures that survives measures 5×5 m, and is built of particularly large stones, of which one course survived. Two monoliths form a distinct entrance, about 80 cm wide. Around the structure are remains of other similar structures, most of which had been bulldozed. A few sherds and flint items are scattered around.

This is a small settlement, without an enclosure, in a typical MBA II format usually found in the higher desert fringes of Samaria (the Gittit-Aqrabeh area). It is possible that this is one of the most easterly examples of this phenomenon.

Pottery: Chalcolithic (?) – 15%; Middle Bronze II – 82%; Late Roman – 3%.

Flint: 23 items, Middle Palaeolithic, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.

Site 199: 19-16/32/1

TAL'AT 'AMREH (2)

Israel grid: 1935/1627

UTM grid: 7322/5496

Elevation: 100 m b.s.l., 100 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: tower

Area: 0.5 dunam (500 sq. m)

Topography: spur edge

Rock type: Avdat Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 2

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Fasa'el pool (171),
3 km distantRoad: Beit She'an–Jericho (B10),
1 km distant

Visit: March 1996; 22 sherds

Remains of a tower built at the edge of a high spur at the south-eastern end of the Sartaba plateau, about 1 km south-west of Yafit. The place is high above the Valley Monument, and there is a fine view to the centre of the Jordan Valley, the settlements Yafit and Fasa'el and the Gilad Mountains.

This round structure is about 8 m in diameter, built of large stones, piled 1 m high, but the original plan is recognizable.

It is likely that the tower served as an observation post overlooking the Jordan Valley. The Hellenistic pottery also suggests that it was part of the fortification system and observation post of the Alexandrion fortress. However, additional research is required in this matter.



393. Remains of the tower at Tal'at 'Amreh (2), 1996 (M. Einav).

Pottery: Iron I (?) – 13%; Hellenistic – 59%; Early Roman – 28%.

Previous surveys: none.



Site 200: 19-16/14/7

WADI AHMAR (9)

Israel grid: 1918/1648

UTM grid: 7304/5516

Elevation: 140 m b.s.l., 0 m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: enclosures

Area: 2 dunams (2000 sq. m)

Topography: valley

Rock type: silt

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: 'Ein el-Mana (176),
1.3 km distant

Road: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C40),
500 m distant

Visit: April 1996; 12 sherds

Enclosures at the centre of the Wadi Ahmar valley, about 3 km north of Fasa'el. Close by to the east is the unpaved road branching from the road which ascends to the Sartaba, and west of it is a shallow stream.

Two quite different architectonic units have been noted here: The northern one is an irregular enclosure, 28 m across. The encircling wall is built of medium-sized stones and has two openings. A wall oriented south-east–north-west enters by one of the openings into the enclosure, perhaps remnants of ancient construction.

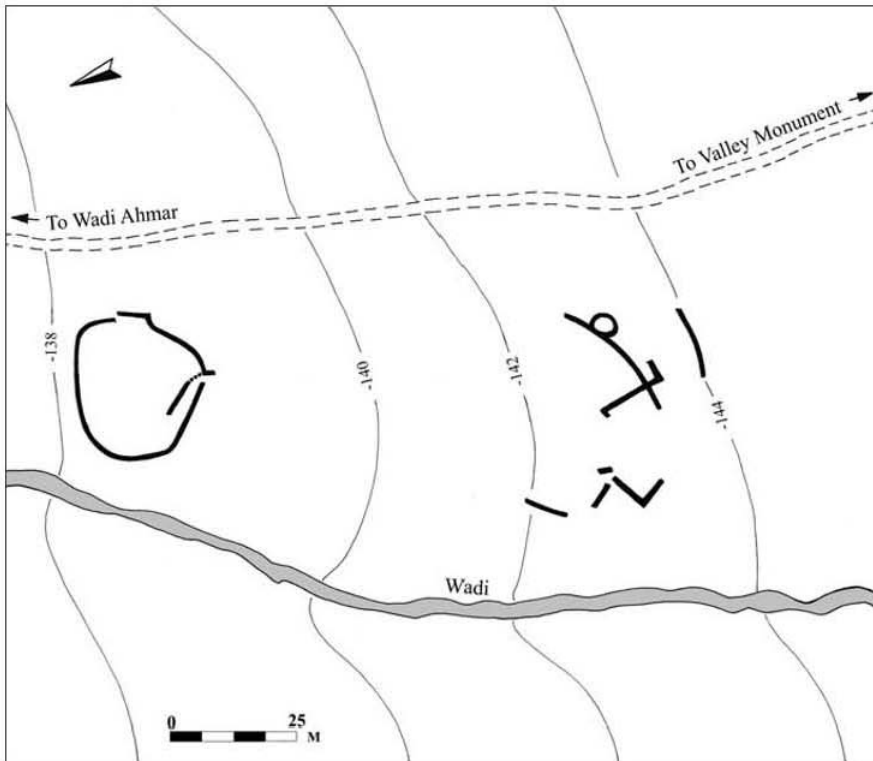
About 100 m further south is the other unit that contains possible remains of a ruined enclosure, whose diameter was larger than the one described above. Attached and entering it are walls, remains of ancient enclosures or rooms. A little further south are the remains of another curved wall.

The number of sherds is small, but it is apparent that the site was constructed and functioned in the IA, while the distinction between the various phases is difficult.

Pottery: Iron I-II – 100%.

Flint: 64 items, see Appendix A.

Previous surveys: none.



394. Plan of Wadi Ahmar (9), 1996.



Site 201: 19-16/12/2

WADI AHMAR (8)

Israel grid: 1912/1625

UTM grid: 7299/5493

Elevation: 18● m b.s.l., 2● m a.s.a.

Name: nearest place

Site type: large

Area: 5● dunams (5 ha)

Topography: valley margins

Rock type: Judea Group

Soil type: stony-desert

Soil quality: 3

Cultivation: none

Cisterns: none

Water source: Fasa'el pool (171),
1 km distantRoad: Fasa'el-Ṭana (C4●),
5●● m distant

Visits: Dec. 1996, 2010; 5● sherds

A large site in the south-western margins of the Wadi Ahmar valley, below Sad Khariz cliffs, and about 8●● m north of the Fasa'el-Maale Ephraim road. About

500 m north-east of the site is the deep and wide riverbed of Wadi Ahmar. The site was built on a high slope, entirely covered by very large boulders and more so by rockfall of huge rocks. The settlement took great advantage of these conditions.

There are two complexes in the site, composed of five main parts:

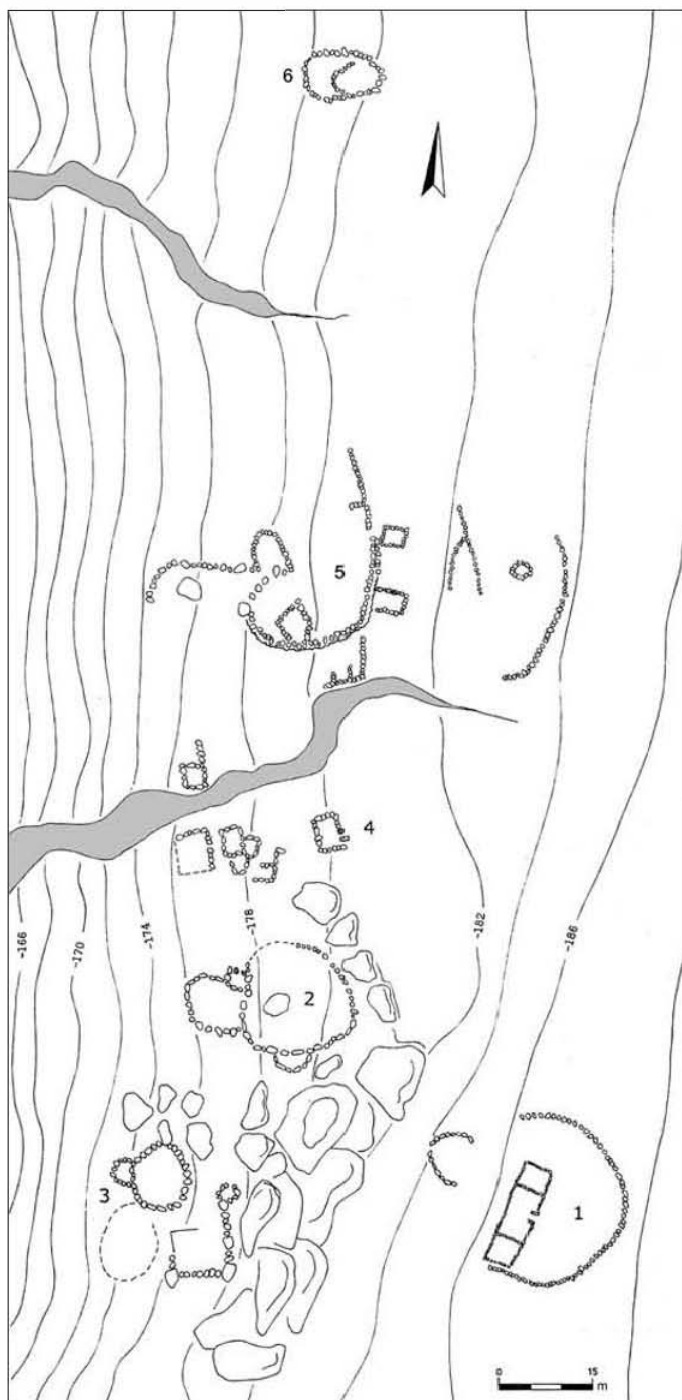
A. The southern part is about 100 m long by 60 m wide in a rockfall of huge boulders which rolled down the slope from the western cliffs. This complex terminates at a small ravine. It includes:

- 1) A large rounded courtyard or enclosure, about 25 m in diameter, whose western upper part is missing. Inside the southern wall of the yard is a long 'broad room' divided into three cells. The structure is 18 m long and 5 m wide. Inside the slightly larger central cell is an opening with door posts (standing monoliths). Slightly north-west, up the slope, is a semi-circular enclosure, open towards the large enclosure.
- 2) Up the slope to the north-west, between the large boulders, is another unit of a courtyard and structure. The yard diameter is about 17 m, and the structure is connected to the west side of the yard. The construction is of especially large stones, up to 500 kg in weight: some of them are slabs laid upright on their long side.
- 3) Further south there are more units and rooms. In all cases the construction is on the natural large rocks.
- 4) North of all the above units, close to the stream, are remains of roomed structures built from large stones, measuring on average about 5×5 m. In most of the rooms the openings are in the form of standing doorposts.

B. The northern part is a complex north of the ravine. Its plan is unclear due to erosion and collapses, but it appears that the settlement in this part was denser than in the southern part. It contains:

- 5) Two large enclosures, with square rooms connected to them. The diameter of the western one is about 30 m, and it has an opening to the west. Inside it and attached to it from the outside were found rectangular and square structures, measuring about 5×5 m, also built of large stones. In addition to these there are also many disconnected walls. Only a section of the encircling wall, walls and a small structure inside the eastern enclosure survived.
- 6) An oval courtyard about 10 m across, about 90 m north of (5) above, beyond another small ravine. Around it are remains of walls and installations, also belonging to the ancient settlement.

This impressive site belongs to the Wadi Ahmar Culture, which includes well-built dwelling sites, but almost without ceramics and flint artifacts. Noteworthy



395. Plan of Wadi Almar (8), 2001.